

Jackson County Historic Truman Courthouse – 112 W Lexington Avenue

Basic Information

The **Jackson County Historic Truman Courthouse** is located at **112 W Lexington Avenue** in Independence, Missouri. It stands in the center of Independence Square, serving as the historic downtown anchor and the absolute heart of regional government, trade, and western migration. Because of its strategic location and dense history, the building represents the political, civic, and historical identity of Independence.

History of the Building

- **1827 – The Original Log Structure:** Jackson County's first frontier log courthouse is erected at the southeast corner of Lexington Avenue and Lynn Street before its eventual removal.
- **1836 – Brick Construction Era:** The permanent brick foundations of the current courthouse are officially laid to accommodate the county's rapid population and economic growth.



Jackson County Courthouse ca 1900

- **1848 to 1907 – Structural Expansions:** As Jackson County grew, the building needed more space and underwent a series of major multi-decade architectural renovations in **1848, 1873, 1887, and 1907**, continuously altering its exterior form, expansion spacing, and clock tower design.

- **1933 – The Truman Modernization:** Presiding Judge Harry S. Truman directs a sweeping architectural overhaul designed by George Fredrick Wallace. This definitive renovation helped shape the courthouse's current appearance, giving it many of its iconic Colonial Revival features, and was celebrated with a historic dedication address by Truman himself.

Connection to Harry S. Truman and Westward Expansion

The courthouse is closely connected to **Harry S. Truman**, who later became the **33rd President of the United States**. Before his presidency, Truman worked in Jackson County government, and this building became an important part of his early political career. Today, visitors can still see spaces related to Truman, including his historic office and courtroom.



Jackson County Presiding Judge Harry S. Truman is speaking at the dedication of the Jackson County Courthouse in Independence, Missouri in 1933



The Santa Fe Trail Marker at the Jackson
County Courthouse in Independence, Mo.

The courthouse is also connected to westward expansion because Independence was one of the most important starting points for migration to the western United States. Many travelers passed through the city before beginning long journeys on the **Oregon Trail**, **Santa Fe Trail**, and **California Trail**. Since the courthouse stood in the center of Independence Square, it was located near the heart of travel, trade, and government activity.

Architecture

Constructed to project formal order, stability, tradition, and enduring civic authority, the building is mainly associated with the **Colonial Revival** style. This style uses classical and early American design elements to express a strong governmental image.

Important architectural features include:

- A perfectly balanced, symmetric public appearance.
- A commanding central clock tower that defines the downtown streetscape skyline.
- Monumental brick construction with refined classical design details.

These features successfully work together to ensure the building appears formal, stable, and historically important



The Jackson County Courthouse 2000 ca

Original and Current Use

Originally, the courthouse was used for county government, administrative work, and judicial functions. It served as a central place for legal decisions and public services in Jackson County.

Today, the building has transitioned from a purely administrative county seat into a preserved, living historic public site. It functions seamlessly as a community archive and cultural center used for educational tours, historical exhibits, and archives interpretation while maintaining active space for ongoing public services. As a result, the courthouse continues to serve the community while effectively preserving its historical importance.

Conclusion

The **Jackson County Historic Truman Courthouse** stands as one of the most meaningful and representative landmarks in Independence, Missouri. Its structural history beautifully mirrors how the urban core developed as a center of government, travel, and national memory. Through its formal classical architecture and its deep connection to President Truman and the western trails, the courthouse continues to anchor the historic character of Independence Square.

101 W. Lexington Avenue

Basic Information

101 W. Lexington Avenue is located on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. After serving for different commercial purposes, nowadays, , the building is used as a modern interactive glass art workshop and gallery.



101 W. Lexington Avenue

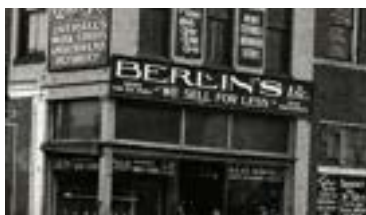
Building Description and Construction Date

According to public property facts and the Missouri historic resources framework, the building at **101 W. Lexington Avenue** is a classic single-story brick commercial storefront originally constructed around **1900**. It stands as an integral contributing asset within the Independence Square Historic District grid. The property contains approximately **1,200 square feet** of adaptable retail floor space.

Businesses Over Time

The building has served commercial purposes for more than a century. Over the years, it housed different businesses, showing how the needs of the local community changed over time.

- **1910 – Golden Rule Clothing House, Mills, Turoff:** Operated as an early high-volume textile and dry goods retail establishment on the corner block.
- **1920 – Sami Turoff Clothing:** Maintained its traditional identity as a specialized downtown garment and fashion shop.



Berlin's Inc. in 1931

- **1930 & 1932 – Berlin's Inc.:** Transitioned to host updated commercial retail mercantile selections.
- **1946 & 1949 – Smith's Shoe Repair & Beauty Shop:** Operated as a dual-service hub, combining craft shoe mechanics with a local neighborhood beauty parlor.
- **1950 – Smith's Shoe Shop, Barber Shop and Jackie Smith's Popcorn:** A vibrant multi-tenant era featuring local grooming services alongside custom sidewalk popcorn retail sales.

- **1952 – Bermaster Shoe Store:** Continued anchoring the block's multi-decade specialization in family footwear supply.
- **1960 – Lane's Shoe Store:** Maintained active neighborhood storefront traffic under classic retail footwear management.
- **1972 – Hobby Corner:** Reimagined to accommodate specialized hobby crafts, games, and community retail inventory.
- **2001 – Western Army Store:** Adapted into a rugged utility and military surplus depot serving regional buyers.

This timeline shows that the building evolved from an early clothing outfitters and dry goods house to shared shoe repair and beauty shops, expanded into retro sidewalk treats and multi-generational shoe stores, and eventually shifted from a hobby depot to a modern creative studio.

Current Use

Today, the building is used as a modern interactive glass art workshop and gallery as a private property.

Conclusion

The building at **101 W. Lexington Avenue** is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Built around **1900**, it has served many different businesses over time, including clothing storefronts, shoe repair shops, family footwear stores, and rugged surplus depots. Today, its use as an interactive art studio continues the building's long commercial history while helping preserve the historic character of downtown Independence.

Mixed Wildflower & Co. - 103 W. Lexington Avenue

Basic Information

Mixed Wildflower & Co. is located at **103 W. Lexington Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building is used as a modern gift, floral shop. However, the structure itself has a much longer history as a commercial storefront.



Mixed Wildflower & Co

Building Description and Construction Date

According to a Missouri historic resources survey, the building at **103 W. Lexington Avenue** is a two-story brick commercial structure. It is considered a contributing historic building within the Independence Square area, meaning it helps preserve the historic character of the district. A commercial real estate record lists the building's construction year as **1897** and the property contains approximately **4,300 to 5,350 square feet** of open flooring.

Businesses Over Time

The building has served commercial purposes for more than a century. Over the years, it housed different businesses, showing how the needs of the local community changed over time.

- **1907 & 1911 – Louis Fournie's Saloon and Poolroom:** Operated as a popular downtown saloon, social poolroom, and gathering hub.
- **1910 – Heckart Cigars:** Housed specialized local tobacco and retail cigar inventory.
- **1920 – People's Market and Clark's Studios:** Functioned simultaneously as a community fresh food market and a professional photography studio.
- **1930 – Missouri Fruit Co., Necessary Real Estate & Gaston & Becker Bowling:** A bustling multi-tenant era featuring a fruit company on the ground floor, alongside a real estate office and a bowling alley operating on the second floor.
- **1940, 1946 & 1950 – The Leader (General Merchandise):** Anchors the block as a prominent multi-decade general merchandise store handling local retail needs.
- **ca. 1950s – Peter's Shoes:** Operated as a dedicated footwear storefront, with historical storefront markings suggesting it was closely interpreted with 'The Leader' business.

- **1960 – Western Army Store:** Transformed into a rugged utility and military army surplus depot serving regional buyers

This timeline shows that the building evolved from a saloon and cigar shop to a market and photography studio, to a fruit company, then to a general merchandise store, to an army surplus store, and eventually a modern boutique.



Western Army Store in 1960

Current Use

Today, **Mixed Wildflower & Co.** continues the building's commercial tradition. It now operates as a local boutique that sells gifts, floral items, and decorative products.

Conclusion

The building at **103 W. Lexington Avenue**, now occupied by **Mixed Wildflower & Co.**, is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Built around **1897**, it has served many different businesses over time, including a saloon, market and photography studio, general merchandise store, and army surplus store. Today, its use as a boutique continues the building's long commercial history while helping preserve the historic character of downtown Independence.

Game Cafe – 107 W. Lexington Avenue

Basic Information

Game Cafe is located at **107 W. Lexington Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, it serves as a community gathering place focused on board games, role-playing games, tournaments, and social events. The building has a long commercial history that reflects the changing needs of Independence residents for more than a century.



Game Café

Building Description and Construction Date



Gibbons Cafe in 1950

According to the Missouri Historic Resources Survey, the building was originally constructed as a **Mission Revival-style commercial building**. When first built, it featured an elaborate shaped parapet above the roofline that gave the structure a much more decorative appearance than it has today. During the mid-twentieth century, the original parapet was removed and the upper façade was covered with corrugated metal siding, significantly altering the building's appearance

One of the building's most distinctive architectural features was the inclusion of both a street-level entrance and a below-grade storefront accessed by stairs. This unusual design allowed for additional commercial space and suggests the building may have been intended for multiple tenants or specialized retail uses from the beginning. Although the façade has been altered over time, traces of its commercial history remain visible. Historic signage from former businesses can still be seen on the building, providing a direct connection to its past occupants.

The Cigar and Restaurant Era & The Barber Shop Decades

Throughout its history, the building housed multiple businesses simultaneously, illustrating how it functioned as a center of commerce and social activity for generations of Independence residents. During the early twentieth century, the building housed both retail and food-service businesses. Shoe stores, cigar shops, restaurants, and lunch counters operated from the location, serving shoppers, travelers, courthouse employees, and local residents visiting Independence Square.

From the **1930s** until the **1950s**, barber shops and beauty parlors became the primary tenants of the building. The repeated appearance of **Cafe Deluxe Barber Shop** under different owners suggests that it was a long-running and well-known establishment. During this era, barber shops served not only as places for grooming but also as important community gathering spaces where residents discussed local politics, business, sports, and courthouse news. Because of its location near county government offices, the business likely attracted attorneys, judges, merchants, and public officials as regular customers.

Businesses Over Time & Key Events

The chronological record of the building's diverse commercial layout tracking changing community demands includes:

- **1910 – Lewis Shoes and Grove Cigars:** Housed retail shoe sales and cigar inventory simultaneously.
- **1920 – Elliott & Kaplanue Restaurant and John W. Grove Cigars:** Served as a dual retail and food-service space on the Square.
- **1930 – Otto Kueffer Barber & Beauty Parlor:** Introduced the grooming and beauty era as a neighborhood gathering point.
- **1940 – Elsen's Cafe Deluxe Barber Shop:** Maintained community operations near county government offices.
- **1946 – Briggs Cafe Deluxe Barber Shop & Beauty Shop and Elsea's Lunch / Cafe:** Combined an expanded grooming suite layout with local diner and lunch counter services.
- **1949 & 1950 – Gibbons Cafe Deluxe Barber Shop and Jay's Buffet:** Continued its long-running multi-tenant identity as a social landmark on the block.
- **1960 – Gibbons Cafe and Missouri Sewing Machine Co.:** Transformed to accommodate a traditional diner setup alongside a specialty sewing retailer.
- **ca. 1970s – Mode O Day:** Transitioned into a specialized retail space anchoring women's fashion trends on the Square.
- **2001 – Blue & Grey Book Shop:** Operated as a dedicated local bookstore, drawing readers and collectors to the historic district.

Current Use



Game Cafe hosts 24 players for Modeen RCQ

Today, the building houses **Game Cafe**, a business that began in **2006** and has expanded over time into multiple levels and adjoining spaces (including hosting prominent tournaments like the 24-player Modeen RCQ). The café serves as a premier gathering place for table gaming and community events, and its current use directly continues the long tradition of social interaction that has characterized the building throughout its history.

Conclusion

The building at **107 W. Lexington Avenue**, now occupied by **Game Cafe**, is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Originally constructed as a **Mission Revival-style** commercial building, it has housed a wide variety of businesses over time, including shoe stores, cigar shops, restaurants, barber shops, beauty parlors, and sewing machine retailers. Today, **Game Cafe** continues the building's long tradition as a place where people gather, socialize, and build community while helping preserve the historic character of downtown Independence.

Self-Propelled Fitness – 109 W. Lexington Avenue

Basic Information

109 W. Lexington Avenue, located on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri, is currently housed by **Self-Propelled Fitness**. Today, it seamlessly continues its long-standing commercial tradition, operating as a premium fitness, training, and wellness hub dedicated to community health.

Self-Propelled Fitness

Building Description and Historical Appearance

Built around **1920** as a specialty retail storefront on Independence Square, **109 W. Lexington Avenue** has served generations of local shoppers, visitors, and community members. The building was already part of the commercial center of Independence during the first half of the twentieth century and contributed to the Square's role as the city's primary business district.

A major remodeling project **during the 1980s** altered the original storefront appearance. Despite these architectural changes, the underlying structure remains an active contributing asset that preserves its historic presence and commercial vitality within the downtown district grid.

Businesses Over Time & Key Events

The storefront has supported a diverse lineage of continuous commercial activity across more than a century:

- **Prior to 1933 to ca. 1949 – Buntings Hardware:** Anchored the storefront for over fifteen years as a core hardware supplier for local residents and tradesmen.
- **1950s – Singer Sewing Machine:** Housed a dedicated retail shop for one of America's most recognizable and iconic domestic appliance brands, establishing a prominent mid-century corporate presence on the block.
- **2001 – Sarsaparilla Dance Hall:** Transformed into a lively social venue and gathering space, reflecting the Square's evolution as an entertainment hub, also associated historically with the LTS name.



Singer Sewing Machine in 1950s

- **ca. 2010 – Primary Colors:** Operated as a colorful specialty retail storefront adding specialized variety to the block.
- **Subsequent Era – Creative Caviar:** Occupied the commercial retail floor space, maintaining continuous business activity on Lexington Avenue.

Current Use

Today, the building is occupied by **Self-Propelled Fitness** (including the Strength Saloon environment). This current use represents a dynamic, modern adaptation of a historic commercial building; rather than housing traditional retail trades, the space now supports community health, fitness, and active engagement while seamlessly continuing its long-standing commercial role on Independence Square.

Conclusion

The building at **109 W. Lexington Avenue** was built around **1920** and it has served a wide variety of commercial and community functions over time. The property has housed businesses ranging from retail stores and markets to social venues and nationally recognized brands such as Singer Sewing Machines. Although remodeled during the **1980s**, the building continues to preserve its historic presence on the Square. Today, its use as a fitness facility continues more than a century of commercial and community activity while contributing to the preservation and vitality of downtown Independence.

Courthouse Exchange – 113 W. Lexington Avenue

Basic Information



Courthouse Exchange

Courthouse Exchange is located at **113 W. Lexington Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, it operates as a restaurant and tavern known for its burgers and historic atmosphere. The business is one of the oldest continuously operating establishments on the Square, with roots dating back to **1899**.

Building Description and Construction Date

According to the Missouri State Parks Jackson County National Register Listings, the structure—known as the **Martin Building**—was constructed around **1909** after a previous building burned down. It is designed as a two-story commercial block featuring prominent storefronts facing the Jackson County Courthouse and is clearly marked at the apex as the "Martin Building". A unique structural element of the property is its limestone-walled basement beneath the sidewalk. Over time, this specific basement space evolved into a tavern and local gathering place that would eventually become the definitive home of the **Courthouse Exchange**.

Historical Appearance



Courthouse Exchange in the 1900s

Unlike many downtown businesses that disappeared during periods of economic decline, the **Courthouse Exchange** continued operating and adapting to changing times. As a result, the building has remained an important part of Independence's historic landscape for more than a century.

Businesses Over Time & Key Events

In its early years, the first floor hosted multiple businesses while the second floor accommodated professional office tenants, including attorneys-at-law and physicians.

The historical timeline of the address and its business foundations includes:

- **1899 – Origins of the Business:** The early foundations of the Courthouse Exchange tavern and social gathering business are officially established on the Square.
- **1909 to 1912 – Martin-Parker Hardware Co.:** Shophouse operations open under the building's original hardware namesake following the structural reconstruction.
- **1911 – The Major and Humphrey:** The retail space hosts specialty men's clothing lines catering to downtown shoppers.
- **1912 – Professional Suites & Hardware:** Housed Thice & Hamilton Attorneys-At-Law, Dr. Oliver C. Sheley, and the Martin Welch Hardware & Plumbing Co.
- **1930s to 1963 – J.C. Penney Co. Era:** Maintained a major retail presence, later receiving a modern marble-style ground floor remodeling.
- **2001 to Present – Courthouse Exchange Restaurant & Tavern:** Officially recognized in architectural surveys as the building's primary modern occupant, serving the public through continuous commerce.
- **2023 – Media Presence:** Highlighting its enduring cultural presence, the venue was famously featured in the Kansas City Chiefs commercial "Falling for Football".

Current Use

Today, the building is occupied by **Courthouse Exchange**, a restaurant and tavern that is particularly known for its burgers and historic atmosphere. Located in the basement level beneath the sidewalk, the restaurant preserves much of the character that has made it a local landmark for generations. The business continues to attract residents and visitors to Independence Square while contributing to the area's economic vitality.



Inside Courthouse Exchange

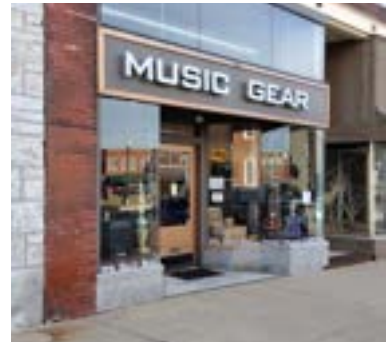
Conclusion

The building at **113 W. Lexington Avenue**, home to the **Courthouse Exchange**, is one of the most historically significant commercial properties on Independence Square. Built around **1899**, it has witnessed more than a century of community life, economic change, and local history. From its limestone-walled basement tavern to its modern role as a popular restaurant, the **Courthouse Exchange** remains a landmark where commerce, politics, dining, and community continue to come together in downtown Independence.

Music Gear – 121 W. Lexington Avenue

Basic Information

Music Gear is located at **121 W. Lexington Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building serves as a local music store specializing in musical instruments and related equipment. However, the structure has a long commercial history dating back more than a century and reflects the growth and development of downtown Independence.



Music Gear

Building Description and Construction Date

The building at **121–123 W. Lexington Avenue** is a historic two-story brick commercial block that dates to the **late 1890s or early 1900s**. According to the Missouri Historic Resources Survey, the structure was built during a period of significant commercial growth on Independence Square. Originally, the building featured:

- Two separate storefronts on the first floor
- A central entrance and stairway leading to the second floor
- Upper-floor office and commercial space
- Large display windows facing Lexington Avenue
- Decorative terra-cotta trim and a metal cornice
- Cast-iron storefront lintels that survive today

Although some decorative parapet features were removed after **1950**, the building retains much of its historic character and is considered a contributing historic structure within the Independence Square Historic District.

Historical Appearance



Music Gear located on the left side of the image.

Historic surveys note that portions of the original storefront and interior features survived well into the twentieth century. Particularly significant is the fact that elements of the interior from the **Yantis-Fritts Drugstore** era were still present when the historic survey was conducted.

Businesses Over Time

Throughout its history, the building has housed a variety of commercial businesses. The building was constructed ca. 1898 and contains two storefronts and two addresses, with office spaces on the second floor accessed via a central staircase. The east storefront (121 W. Lexington), now occupied by Music Gear, was most notably associated with pharmacies and drugstores.

The documented lineage of businesses includes:

- **1907 to 1914 – Mize Drug Co.:** Housed early drugstore operations during a period of significant commercial growth on the Square.
- **1914 to 1944 – Yantis-Fritts Drug Co.:** Operated for approximately thirty years, making it one of the longest-running businesses known to have occupied the building.



Mize Drug co. Advertisement

- **1950 – Office Space:** The storefront transitioned temporarily into commercial office spaces during the mid-century era.
- **1960 – Bunyar Drug Store:** Returned to its traditional roots as a downtown pharmacy serving local residents.
- **2001 – Pioneer Trails Barbeque and Trading Post:** Adapted to accommodate a local restaurant and specialized trading storefront.

Current Use

Today, the building is home to **Music Gear**, a locally owned music store serving musicians and residents throughout the Independence area. Its current use continues the building's long-standing commercial tradition while adapting the space to modern community needs. The store contributes to the economic activity of Independence Square and helps maintain the area's role as a destination for local shopping and services.



Music Gear – Inside the store

Conclusion

The building at **121 W. Lexington Avenue**, now occupied by **Music Gear**, is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Constructed in the late nineteenth or early twentieth century, it has served a variety of commercial purposes over more than a century. Best known for housing the Yantis-Fritts Drugstore for nearly thirty years, the building retains significant architectural and historical features that contribute to the character of downtown Independence. Today, Music Gear continues the building's commercial legacy while supporting the preservation and vitality of the historic Square.

First National Bank Building

Basic Information



Bank of America

First National Bank Building is located at **129 W. Lexington Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building functions as a multi-tenant commercial and professional landmark. However, the structure itself has a much longer history as a powerhouse financial and civic hub.

Building Description and Construction Date

The commanding structure occupies a prominent corner lot at **129 W. Lexington Avenue**, having historically expanded to encompass the adjoining 127 W. Lexington lot, which was the original home of the Home Deposit Trust Co. Both the Missouri State Parks Architectural Surveys and the Missouri State Parks Jackson County National Register Listings treat these integrated parcels as a unified structural asset under the 129 W. Lexington designation.

Businesses Over Time

The building has served essential commercial and financial purposes for well over a century. Over the years, it housed a dynamic mix of different businesses and prestigious service offices, showing how the financial infrastructure of Jackson County evolved over time.

- **Early Foundation – First National Bank:** Established prominent banking operations, anchoring the high-impact corner lot as a principal financial institution for the community.



First National Bank

- **1906 – Sturgis & Deffendack Jewelers and Opticians:** Shared the valuable commercial footprint, providing upscale luxury watchmaking, jewelry lines, and specialized optical services.
- **1906 – Walter Rider & Co. Real Estate & Loans:** Housed an active Edwardian-era property desk managing real estate operations and regional investment loans.
- **Subsequent Era – Boatmen’s Bank:** Transitioned to host the regional banking network, maintaining the block's multi-decade role as a foundational financial site.

- **Modern Corporate Era – Bank of America:** Operated under the major national financial banner, driving retail banking and community business transactions in the heart of downtown.

This timeline shows that the building evolved from independent local trust operations and early Edwardian property desks to a multi-tenant hub hosting mid-century banking mergers, prominent modern national banking networks, and contemporary service corporate entities.

Current Use

Today, the building maintains its commanding presence on Independence Square, standing as a pristine architectural landmark. Its contemporary function continues the site's multi-tenant commercial legacy, blending historic stone-and-brick preservation with modern corporate and service activities that actively fuel the economic revitalization of the downtown district.

Conclusion

The **First National Bank** Building at **129 W. Lexington Avenue** is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Built as an institutional powerhouse corner block, it has served many different high-profile tenants over time, including jewelers, real estate operators, and local corporate banking giants. Today, its adaptive use continues the building's long commercial history while helping preserve the historic character and walking vitality of downtown Independence.

Blue Ridge Bank & Trust Co. – 201 W. Lexington Avenue

Basic Information



Blue Ridge Bank & Trust Co.

Blue Ridge Bank & Trust Co. is located at **201 W. Lexington Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building houses the bank's Square Branch, along with professional offices and governmental services.

Building Description and Historical Significance

What makes **201 W. Lexington Avenue** unique is that the history of the property and the history of the current building are not the same. Evidence suggests that today's structure is a **mid-twentieth-century replacement** for an earlier building that once occupied the site.

The property enjoys a premium location, occupying the northwest corner intersection of Lexington Avenue and Liberty Street. It sits directly overlooking the courthouse grounds, standing at one of the most visible intersections on the Square. This high-impact corner lot has long been occupied by financial institutions, serving as an absolute anchor of trade and financial activity since the nineteenth century.

Multi-Floor Professional Ecosystem

Throughout the property's history, both the original **1869** block and the current building contained three floors. The typical layout includes a banking room or financial suite occupying the ground floor, while the upper-floor spaces have accommodated a diverse array of tenants at various times, including:

- Law offices and legal practices.
- Dental offices and practices.
- County and municipal government offices and bureaus.
- Local fraternal organizations and secret rooms.

Business Over Time & Key Events

The chronological record of this landmark banking site highlights over **150 years** of uninterrupted financial and civic utility on the block:

- **1869 to 1963 – The Original Chrisman-Sawyer Building:** Commenced nearly a century of financial services on the corner inside a grand, three-story brick structure.



Chrisman-Sawyer Building in 1917.

- **1963 – Modern Structural Replacement:** The original 19th-century block is razed to the ground and replaced by the current modern three-story layout. Chrisman-Sawyer Bank continued retail operations within the newly constructed facility.
- **1995 to 2010 – Hillcrest Bank:** Operated under a new banner following a corporate merger with Chrisman-Sawyer Bank in 1995, seamlessly maintaining the site's rich banking heritage.
- **2019 to Present – Blue Ridge Bank & Trust Co.:** Formally opened its dynamic Square Branch at this location, driving modern commercial transactions.

Current Use

Today, the building functions as a multi-tenant ecosystem that blends modern retail financial suites alongside county and municipal government offices, administrative professional spaces, and active civic functions. These synchronized uses perfectly continue the site's long-standing role as a center of commerce and public activity on Independence Square.

Conclusion

The property at **201 W. Lexington Avenue** occupies one of the most significant and visible corners on Independence Square. While the current building is a mid-twentieth-century structure, the site itself has played a foundational role in the city's commercial and civic life since the nineteenth century. Today, **Blue Ridge Bank & Trust Co.** successfully continues this legacy, providing premier banking and professional services while helping to preserve the historic character of downtown Independence.

Be Here Now – 205–207 W. Lexington Avenue

Basic Information



Be Here Now

Be Here Now is located at **205–207 W. Lexington Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building serves as a specialty retail business and community gathering space. Historically known as the **Gentry Building**, the property demonstrates how Independence Square continues to evolve rather than remaining frozen in its nineteenth-century appearance.

Building Description and Construction Date

Unlike many neighboring structures that date to the late nineteenth century, this building was constructed **circa 1938–1940**, making it one of the newer historic properties on the Square. The Gentry Building occupies an expanded commercial footprint that seamlessly spans both the 205 and 207 W. Lexington lots.

While traditional neighboring buildings feature Victorian and early commercial architectural styles with tall facades, ornate brickwork, terra-cotta ornamentation, and decorative cornices, the Gentry Building stands out sharply as a striking, geometric example of clean, non-ornamental **mid-century Modern architecture**. Highly celebrated for its streamlined and modernist design language, it reflected contemporary design trends of the period and stood out as a symbol of progress and modernization when it was constructed.

Key architectural and design traits include:

- Clean horizontal lines and bands.
- Smooth concrete outer panels and surfaces.
- Reinforced concrete support systems and construction.
- Large street-level display windows and apertures.
- An absolute absence of classical or classical Art Deco-influenced ornamentation.

Businesses Over Time & Key Events

The building has continued its prominent role as a commercial destination for generations, adapting its interior fluidly across several notable eras:

- **Late 1800s to Late 1930s – The Banking Era:** Operated continuously as a regional financial hub housing the McCoy Bank and Southern Bank systems until structural demolition.

- **1938 – Modernist Reconstruction:** The current Gentry Building is officially erected on the combined lots, introducing Streamline Moderne aesthetics to Lexington Avenue.
- **1938 to 1963 – Tucker Furniture Store:** Headquartered the prominent local furniture showroom, anchoring heavy retail traffic across the mid-1900s.
- **1969 to ca. 2001 – Turner Music:** Transformed into a legendary downtown musical instrument shop and specialty retail showroom for over three decades.

Current Use

Today, the building functions as **Be Here Now**. Its contemporary adaptation beautifully preserves the pristine 1938 architectural envelope while thoroughly modernizing the indoor floor space to support active neighborhood commerce, local wellness retail, and social collaboration on the Square



Inside Be Here Now

Conclusion

The building at **205–207 W. Lexington Avenue**, now home to **Be Here Now**, is an important part of Independence Square's architectural history. Constructed around **1940**, the Gentry Building represents Independence's effort to modernize its downtown during the early twentieth century. Unlike many neighboring Victorian-era buildings, it embraced the Moderne style and reflected changing commercial trends. From Tucker Furniture Store to Turner Music and now Be Here Now, the building has continued its role as a commercial destination while contributing to the historic character and vitality of downtown Independence.

Café Verona – 206 W. Lexington Avenue

Basic Information

Café Verona is located at **206 W. Lexington Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building operates as a popular Italian restaurant and central social meeting ground for residents. While currently unified to house the restaurant, this property historically comprised two independent buildings (204 and 206 W. Lexington Avenue) with a long history of hospitality and community interaction.



Café Verona

Building Description and Historical Background

The underlying structures were constructed independently **in the 1880s**. Historic surveys identify the property as part of a collection of late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century commercial storefronts that helped establish Independence Square as the city's primary business district.

Like many commercial structures of the frontier era, the buildings were designed with a distinct dual-purpose framework:

- Ground-floor hospitality and retail space maximized for street-level storefront exposure.
- Shared party walls with neighboring buildings to optimize the downtown block grid.
- A flat roofline concealed behind an ornate decorative parapet.
- Dedicated second-floor professional suites.

This architectural layout preserved an ecosystem where historical professionals—including attorneys-at-law, insurance agents, and physicians—operated directly above the bustling downtown retail district.

Architectural Evolution

The property demonstrates how historic downtown storefronts continuously adapt to changing community needs across generations. Over more than a century, the buildings underwent several remodeling phases, which included:

- Replacing original frontier wooden storefronts with large plate-glass display windows.
- Installing metal awnings and modernizing public entrances.
- Updating retail commercial signage.
- Covering or altering decorative architectural details.

During the historical district survey conducted in 2001, the site was documented as being actively under construction to unify the spaces. Because of these patterns of adaptive reuse, the buildings still contain much of their original historic structure and masonry bones beneath their updated modern facades.

Businesses Over Time & Key Events

Throughout their history, the ground-floor spaces supported multiple concurrent businesses, functioning as a vital center of commerce on the Square.

204 W. Lexington Avenue Lineage:

- **Latter part of the 1800s:** It likely housed a traditional barbershop during the town square's heyday.
- **1910 – White Sewing Machine:** Housed specialized domestic appliance retail sales.
- **1930s & 1940s – Keehnell Jewelry Co., Inc.:** Occupied by a prominent fine jewelry business owned and operated by Roy B. Keehnell.
- **Early 1990s:** It transitioned to house the inventory and customer service operations of a local drugstore.
- **2002 to Present – Café Verona:** Unified into the modern restaurant footprint.

206 W. Lexington Avenue (The Milner Building) Lineage:

- **Early Years:** Operated as a traditional downtown lunchroom.
- **1910 to 1920s – Milner Cafe:** Housed a restaurant and fresh grocery depot owned and operated by Thomas W. Milner during the first couple decades of the century.
- **1930 – E.F. Bracht Restaurant:** Maintained the site's ongoing culinary footprint.
- **1930 to 1950 – Herbert A. Major Barber Shop:** Housed a long-running neighborhood barber shop. During the 1930s, the barber explicitly shared the physical address with a dining restaurant, creating a multi-tenant social hub where residents gathered to cut hair and discuss local politics, court news, and business.
- **1963 to 1965 – Jones Store:** Occupied by a business under the Jones name (noted in surveys as likely distinct from the major department store network).

Current Use



Inside Café Verona

Today, the building is occupied by **Café Verona**, operating strictly as a premier fine-dining Italian restaurant. Its contemporary adaptation perfectly utilizes the traditional, open-concept ground floor to deliver an unmatched atmosphere of community hospitality while preserving its original historic structure beneath the updated facade.

Conclusion

The building at **206 W. Lexington Avenue**, now home to **Café Verona**, is an important part of the historic fabric of Independence Square. Constructed during the period when Independence was growing into a regional commercial center, the building has long contributed to the economic and social life of the city. Although its appearance has evolved over time, it continues to serve the same essential purpose: bringing people together in the center of the community.

Farmers & Merchants Bank Building – 101 N. Main Street

Basic Information

Farmers & Merchants Bank Building is located at **101 N. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the ground floor of the historic building hosts **On the Square Nutrition**, offering healthy wellness blends.



Farmers & Merchant Bank Building –
Nutrition on the Square

Building Description and Architecture

Originally constructed in **1885** with significant structural modifications around **1921**, this multi-story brick landmark commands a premier anchor position on North Main Street. As documented by the Jackson County Historical Society, the building features classic late-nineteenth-century commercial masonry designed to handle high-traffic ground-floor retail alongside expansive multi-purpose upper levels.

Businesses Over Time

This prominent structure has served as an essential center for both finance and community lifestyle for generations of Independence residents. Its diverse architectural footprint fluidly adapted across the twentieth century:



Farmers & Merchant Bank in the 1990s

- **1885 – Farmers & Merchants Bank:** Commenced its active financial footprint on the block, operating as a foundational banking institution for early regional merchants and farmers
- **1910 – McClintink Confectionery Shop:** Transformed into a popular downtown sweet shop and community gathering point.
- **1920 – Mike Santoro & Son Fruit & Produce:** Adapted into a dedicated neighborhood fresh food and bulk agricultural produce market.
- **1924 – 3rd Floor – Harpie Club:** Welcomed a unique local social organization and private gathering layout to the building's third-story floor space.

- **1946 – Reliable Loan Co:** Shifted back to financial utility, operating as a localized commercial credit and consumer loan office.
- **1950 – Davis Paint Store:** Reimagined into a dedicated mid-century home design, hardware retail storefront, and supply hub.

This timeline shows that the building evolved from a late-nineteenth-century frontier merchant bank to popular sweet confectionery shops and fresh agricultural produce markets, before adapting into third-floor private social clubs, mid-century commercial credit loan offices, home hardware paint hubs, and modern commercial wellness nutrition bars.

Current Use

Today, the ground floor of the historic **1885** building hosts **On the Square Nutrition**. By perfectly preserving its striking **late-Victorian brick** exterior while continuously adapting its indoor layout to support healthy lifestyle retail, the property beautifully bridges its grand financial heritage with the active, walkable commercial vitality of downtown Independence.

Conclusion

The Farmers & Merchants Bank Building at **101 N. Main Street** is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Built around **1885**, it has served many different businesses over time, including early local financial institutions, sweet storefronts, produce operations, and paint retailers. Today, its use as a commercial health club continues the building's long commercial history while helping preserve the historic character and walking vitality of downtown Independence.

Bundschu's Department Store Building

Basic Information

Bundschu's Department Store Building is located at **103 N. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building houses Heartland Center for Behavioral Change Independence Outpatient Clinic, that functions as an active outpatient clinic providing behavioral health and substance use disorder recovery services .



Heartland Center for Behavioral Change
Independence Outpatient Clinic

Building Description and Architecture

Built in **1928**, this imposing commercial brick structure was engineered specifically to support a grand, multi-level department store format. As documented by the Jackson County Historical Society, the current building replaced an earlier nineteenth-century entertainment landmark on the same plot, featuring massive street-facing window bays designed to showcase premium retail displays to walking traffic.

Businesses Over Time

The building has served essential commercial and civic purposes for generations. Over the years, it housed different businesses and public functions, showing how the needs of the local community shifted from downtown luxury retail to municipal administration.

- **18xx? – Wilson Opera House:** Commenced its structural legacy on the site as a premier frontier-era theater, cultural gathering space, and opera hall.
- **1900 – Bundschu's Department Store (First Floor):** Establishes its retail footprint by leasing the ground floor of the original Wilson Opera House building.



Bundschu's Department Store

- **1928 – Bundschu's Department Store (Current Building):** The grand, modern replacement structure is officially erected on the lot to anchor Bundschu's expanding retail empire.
- **1959 – Emery, Bird, Bundschu's Department Store:** Transformed through a major high-profile retail partnership, operating as a multi-floor destination for fine apparel, homewares, and community shopping.

- **1973 – Independence Municipal Building:** Acquired and adapted by the local government to host centralized city administration bureaus and public safety desks.
- **1978 – Various Offices:** Reimagined into a highly versatile multi-tenant commercial property housing diverse professional suites and local businesses.

This timeline shows that the building evolved from a frontier-era opera house and early independent dry goods operations into a massive collaborative regional department store network, before transitioning into an essential municipal facility and a versatile multi-tenant commercial space.

Current Use

Today, the historic **1928 Bundschu Building** houses the **Heartland Center for Behavioral Change Independence Outpatient Clinic**. By maintaining its striking brick facade and continuous structural utility, it bridges the Golden Age of twentieth-century retail history with critical, community-focused healthcare resources that support the wellness and active engagement of downtown Independence.

Conclusion

The **Bundschu's Department Store Building** at **103 N. Main Street** is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Built as a grand replacement structure for a nineteenth-century entertainment landmark, it has served many different roles over time, including an opera hall, a premier department store empire, and a centralized city administration facility. Today, its use continues the building's long commercial history while helping preserve the historic character and adaptive vitality of downtown Independence

3 Trails Brewing – 111 N. Main Street

Basic Information



3 Trails Brewing

3 Trails Brewing is located at **111 N. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Opened in **2019**, this independent craft brewery, tasting taproom, and social venue stands as a dynamic monument to the city's frontier past. The establishment is named explicitly in honor of the three legendary historic pathways—the Santa Fe, Oregon, and California Trails—that natively converged at the Square parameters.

Building Description and Construction Date

The property at **111 N. Main Street** is a historic two-story brick commercial retail and office structure erected around the late nineteenth century. Positioned on the eastern sector of the city grid, it forms a vital pillar of the historic commercial district that has served as the absolute center of business and neighborhood life for more than a century.

While the facade seamlessly showcases its classic, century-old brick masonry, the interior spans an adaptable floor map that has continuously supported high-volume local commerce while fluidly evolving to meet the community's changing retail demands.

Independence and the Westward Staging Heritage

The name "**3 Trails Brewing**" pays direct cultural homage to Independence's historic role as America's ultimate national transport and westward outfitting hub during the nineteenth century. The convergence of the **Santa Fe, Oregon, and California Trails** brought a steady influx of international merchants, frontier travelers, and pioneer settlers through the city. This intensive traffic allowed early Main Street shopkeepers to build massive fortunes, permanently cementing the district as an essential center of wealth and trade in Western America.

Businesses Over Time

Available property facts indicate that the building has maintained an active, uninterrupted commercial legacy for generations, transitioning through iconic retail formats before its modern culinary adaptation:

- **1890 – Henry Jott Furniture Company / Sampsons Men's Clothing:** Commenced its commercial footprint housing high-volume home furnishings alongside specialized men's apparel.
- **1926 – Charles Tucker Furniture Store / Drug Store:** Transformed into a neighborhood drug store and retail furniture showroom.
- **1929 – Tucker Furniture Store / S.S. Kresge Co. Expansion:** Accommodated the initial expansion of the iconic S.S. Kresge national variety store network on the block alongside furniture sales.
- **1951 – S.S. Kresge Department Store:** Operated fully under the famous national variety store banner, driving massive daily foot traffic and consumer lifestyle retail to Main Street.
- **1971 – Sears Surplus:** Adapted into a rugged regional Sears outlet hub handling general household appliances and retail surplus inventory.
- **1980s – The Emporium Stores:** Reimagined as a centralized multi-tenant local shopping center and boutique market layout, preserving commercial space under a unified retail hub.
- **2019 to Present – 3 Trails Brewing Co.:** Converted into a modern independent craft taproom, microbrewery, and community social space.



Retail and Office Use - The Emporium

Current Use

Today, the building functions as the active headquarters for **3 Trails Brewing Co.** Perfectly marrying its raw, century-old brick character with contemporary community design, the venue operates as a craft brewery, tasting taproom, and localized downtown revitalization anchor. It offers a premium variety of house-crafted beers, successfully serving as a high-energy gathering place for local residents and traveling history enthusiasts.

Conclusion

The building at **111 N. Main Street**, now occupied by **3 Trails Brewing**, remains an important part of Independence Square's commercial landscape. Constructed around **1900**, it has served generations of businesses and customers as part of the city's historic downtown district. Today, 3 Trails Brewing connects Independence's past and present by celebrating the city's trail heritage while providing a modern gathering place for the community.

Ophelia 's Restaurant & Inn – 201 N. Main Street

Basic Information

Ophelia's Restaurant & Inn is beautifully located at **201 N. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building functions seamlessly as an upscale fine-dining restaurant, premier community event space, and an elegant upper-story boutique inn overlooking the Square. Standing as a primary anchor for downtown revitalization, it proudly continues a multi-generational tradition of hospitality, celebration, and active local commerce.



Ophelia's Restaurant & Inn

Building Description and Construction Date

The architectural footprint represents a fascinating combination of two distinct construction periods that mirror the modernization of the Square district. The original front storefront facade was built **around 1907** to house early-century hardware mercantile operations. Decades later, a massive rear structural extension was completed in **1948** to facilitate a grand, post-war expansion of the downtown retail footprint. Because these separate eras were structurally bridged, the property offers highly adaptable internal volumes, seamlessly expanding from the street-front dining rooms into expansive banquet facilities and a deep basement network.

The Katz Drugstore Era

From the **late 1940s through the mid-1970s**, the building evolved into one of the largest, highest-volume retail powerhouses on Independence Square. Famously operating under prominent regional drug banners, it completely revolutionized traditional commercial foot traffic on Main Street.

The pinnacle of this era began in **1948** with the arrival of the iconic **Katz Drug Store**. This commercial powerhouse was an ecosystem unto itself, employing approximately 175 people across 13 highly specialized departments. Beyond traditional pharmacy counters, the massive floor plan accommodated a bustling local snack bar, a popular soda fountain, and even a dedicated pet department, serving as a massive community gathering node until the mid-1970s.



Katz Drug Store in 1948

Businesses Over Time

The property boasts a rich commercial legacy, fluidly adapting its square footage to match the shifting lifestyle needs of Independence residents across generations:

- **1907 – Hill & Martin Hardware Store:** Opened its doors as a prominent early-century hardware depot handling local tools, agricultural implements, and building supplies.
- **1918 – Hill Brothers Hardware:** Maintained continuous neighborhood utility under updated and dedicated family hardware management.
- **1948 – Katz Drug Store:** Transformed via a major structural expansion into an iconic multi-department commercial powerhouse.
- **1971 – Skaggs Drug Store:** Transitioned to host the prominent mid-century Skaggs national retail network, continuing pharmacy and merchandise utility.
- **1980 – Spirit of '76:** Reimagined to accommodate specialized commercial and community retail initiatives during a shifting downtown economic landscape.
- **1998 to Present – Ophelia's Restaurant & Inn:** Converted into a high-end hospitality destination, elegantly bridging 20th-century preservation with modern luxury.

Current Use

Named thoughtfully after Mary Pipher's book *Reviving Ophelia*, the building has been meticulously adapted into a dual-purpose luxury destination. The lower floors host fine-dining setups and robust banquet spaces, while the upper story offers elegant boutique lodging accommodations. Featuring uniquely curated guest rooms that look directly out onto the courthouse grounds, the inn allows traveling tourists and historic enthusiasts to fully experience the authentic atmosphere of downtown Independence.

Conclusion

The building at **201 N. Main Street**, now home to **Ophelia's Restaurant & Inn**, is an important part of Independence Square's commercial history. Originally constructed as Hills Brothers Hardware around 1907 and later expanded as part of the Katz Drugstore renovation in 1948, the property has served generations of Independence residents. Today, its combination of restaurant, event space, and inn continues the building's tradition of hospitality and community activity while preserving its connection to the historic Square.

Pickens Sweet Treats – 205 N Main Street

Basic Information

Pickens Sweet Treats is located at **205 N. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the property functions today as **Pickens Sweet Treats - Candy Shop**. Operating as a premier, family-owned confectionery venue, the storefront serves as a delightful independent anchor along the North Main Street pedestrian corridor.



Pickens Sweet Treat

Building Description and Historical Context

The building at **205 N. Main Street** forms an integral part of a continuous commercial brick block that has reliably served downtown residents, courthouse visitors, and tourists for generations. While its exact architectural construction date remains an open canvas for future archival research, the building's physical form is highly consistent with the early twentieth-century commercial development that swept across Independence Square. Engineered with the classic layout of traditional pedestrian trade, it features a flexible ground-floor footprint, shared masonry party walls, and large street-level display windows designed to warmly welcome shoppers passing by.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information.

Current Use

While the building's earliest occupancy records are still being uncovered by digital preservation surveys, its modern chapter is defined by the unique, handcrafted culinary art of the Pickens family. Owned and operated by sisters Natalie and Nanette Pickens, the business has successfully established a rock-solid reputation as a popular stop for families exploring the downtown core. The boutique shop focuses on high-quality artisanal production and custom gifting:

- **Handmade Confections:** Small-batch gourmet toffees, rich creams, and specialty fudge.
- **Artisanal Baking:** Handcrafted chocolates, seasonal cookies, and signature sweets.
- **Curated Merchandising:** Intricate gift baskets and tailored treats designed to celebrate local community events and holidays.



Conclusion

The building at **205 N. Main Street** represents the enduring power of specialized, family-owned commerce on Independence Square. Moving past its anonymous early mercantile foundations, its modern adaptation into **Pickens Sweet Treats** showcases how historic structures can gracefully evolve to meet modern lifestyle trends while preserving their historic streetscape character. By matching vintage brick architecture with the sweet tradition of handcrafted candy, this storefront ensures that the warm, entrepreneurial spirit of the historic district continues to thrive for future generations.

H&R Block - 207 N. Main Street

Basic Information

The building at **207 N. Main Street**, now occupied by **H&R Block**, is part of the historic commercial fabric of downtown Independence. Although detailed early records for the building are limited, its location near Independence Square connects it to the city's long history of business, public service, and community life. Today, its use as a financial services office continues the building's role as a place of business in the heart of Independence.



H&R Block Building

Building Description and Historical Context

The structure at **207 N. Main Street** forms an integral part of the continuous commercial rows lining the North Main Street corridor. While detailed early archival records for this specific property remain limited, its physical architecture aligns with the traditional early twentieth-century storefront layouts surrounding the Jackson County Historic Truman Courthouse. Engineered for high structural adaptability, the building features a pedestrian-facing retail or service space, shared masonry party walls, and large display windows designed to capture downtown traffic. Its strategic location near Independence Square deeply connects it to the city's multi-generational history of commerce, public service, and active community life.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information

Current Use: Corporate and Financial Service Continuity

Today, the storefront fully utilizes its classic commercial layout to operate as a local office for **H&R Block**. By providing essential tax preparation and financial planning services to residents, business owners, and courthouse professionals, the venue drives consistent daytime foot traffic to the Main Street trade corridor. This modern service demonstrates how historic commercial properties can easily pivot to house established corporate networks while maintaining the active, walkable character of the historic downtown district.

Conclusion

The building at **207 N. Main Street** represents the enduring commercial utility and structural resilience of Independence Square. Moving past its anonymous early merchant history, its modern chapter as an **H&R Block** financial hub showcases the value of professional service spaces within a historic framework. By successfully matching a traditional early-twentieth-century storefront appearance with essential corporate services, this structural anchor ensures that the business legacy of downtown Independence remains economically productive for future generations.

Scandinavia Place - 209 N. Main Street

Basic Information



Scandinavia Place is located at **209 N. Main Street** on the historic **Independence Square** in Independence, Missouri. Today, the storefront is occupied by a specialty import and gift shop known for Scandinavian foods, gifts, candies, seasonal products, and cultural items.

Scandinavia Place

Building Description and Historical Context

The building at **209 N. Main Street** forms an integral part of the continuous, historic commercial streetscape lining the North Main Street corridor. While a definitive construction date has not yet been confirmed in digital archival records, the building's physical structure aligns with the major commercial development boom of Independence Square during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.

During this transformative era, many downtown properties were engineered or updated into resilient two-story brick commercial blocks, featuring dedicated pedestrian-facing retail or service layouts on the ground floor with professional offices, communal meeting rooms, or flexible storage suites above.

A Remarkable Four-Decade Specialty Anchor

The most prominent and historically significant chapter in the building's contemporary history is its defining role as **Scandinavia Place**. Available commercial business records confirm that the boutique has operated seamlessly out of **209 N. Main Street** since at least **1987**.

This multi-decade tenure is highly significant within the economic framework of Independence Square. While traditional downtown storefronts naturally experience high turnover rates and shifting retail trends over time, Scandinavia Place has outstandingly resisted commercial fluctuations. Remaining anchored to the exact same square footage for approximately four decades, it stands as one of the longest-running active independent retail venues on the Square. The shop's specialized inventory showcases:

- **Specialty Foods & Candies:** Imported Scandinavian delicacies, traditional groceries, and European confectionery.
- **Artisanal Décor & Gifts:** Handcrafted home accents, seasonal items, and authentic cultural goods.
- **Heritage Preservation:** Unique regional merchandise that serves as a living connection to Scandinavian cultural traditions.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information

Current Use

Today, **Scandinavia Place** masterfully utilizes its classic storefront layout to cultivate a highly distinctive, nostalgic shopping experience. By pairing its historic early-twentieth-century architectural character with a deeply curated European marketplace environment, the storefront is occupied by a specialty import and gift shop known for Scandinavian foods, gifts, candies, seasonal products, and cultural items.

Conclusion

The building at **209 N. Main Street** represents a triumph of commercial longevity and structural resilience on Independence Square. Moving past its anonymous early merchant foundations, its nearly forty-year history as the home of **Scandinavia Place** showcases the immense power of specialized retail survival. By beautifully matching vintage brick architecture with a deeply rooted tradition of international imports, this classic Main Street storefront remains a central component of downtown Independence's unique identity and modern community life.

Gateway Sporting Goods - 213 N. Main Street

Basic Information

Gateway Sporting Goods Building is located at **213 N. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building preserves its



original 19th-century structural brick envelope while remaining an active part of the ongoing revitalization of downtown Independence. However, the structure itself has a much longer history as a remarkably adaptable storefront.

Gateway Sporting Goods

Building Description and Architecture

Erected during the booming **1890s** expansion era, this versatile single-story brick commercial building stands as a highly adaptable structural asset within the Independence Square Historic District. As documented by the Jackson County Historical Society, the building features a classic **late-Victorian commercial** facade engineered to support rotating high-traffic retail formats.

Businesses Over Time

This specific location boasts one of the most uniquely diverse adaptive reuse records on the entire Square. Over a 130-year span, the interior square footage was repeatedly reconfigured to support everything from back-of-house hospitality logistics and municipal law enforcement to heavy industrial metal distribution and popular mid-century community dining rooms.

- **1890s – Kitchen for Hotel:** Commenced its utility as a dedicated service facility and commercial kitchen layout supporting a nearby downtown hotel.
- **1908 – City Marshal Office:** Transformed into a vital public safety asset, housing the official headquarters for the local City Marshal operations.
- **1910 – Auto Supplies:** Shifted to capture the early automotive boom, operating as an early-century specialized parts and tire depot.
- **1911 – Thomas Confectioners:** Reimagined into a sweet neighborhood gathering spot selling traditional candies and baked goods.
- **1913 – Benjamin Lewis Dry Goods:** Anchored the block as a multi-line textile, clothing, and general merchandise mercantile store.
- **1923 – Sprangler Grocer:** Served the neighborhood as a dedicated local fresh food and dry grocery market.
- **1929 – Sturm Furniture:** Operated as a downtown home furniture showroom and commercial retail floor space.

- **1940 – The Hounds:** Welcomed a unique specialized local business concept to the Main Street storefront.
- **1942 – Independence Iron & Metal Co.:** Adapted during the World War II industrial era into a commercial supply desk for iron and metal components.
- **1957 – Main Street Grill:** Returned to its culinary roots as a popular mid-century walkable diner and community social restaurant.

- **1966 – Gateway Sporting Goods Co.:** Became a highly celebrated regional landmark, anchoring the block as a premier outfitter for sports gear, apparel, and hardware.



Gateway Sporting Goods & Co

- **1986 – The Keeping Room Antiques:** Transitioned into a specialized vintage showcase, preserving the building's historic charm through antique retail commerce.

This timeline shows that the building evolved from back-of-house hotel hospitality and early public safety offices to automotive parts suppliers, candy counters, and grocery markets, before shifting to furniture showrooms, war-era metal supply desks, classic walkable diners, regional sporting outfitters, and specialized antique showcases.

Current Use

Today, the building preserves its original 19th-century structural brick envelope while remaining an active part of the ongoing revitalization of downtown Independence. By continuously bridging historic preservation with local walkable commerce, it maintains active visual and economic continuity on the eastern perimeter of the Square grid.

Conclusion

The **Gateway Sporting Goods Building** at **213 N. Main Street** is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Built as a late-Victorian commercial brick asset, it has served an exceptional array of diverse tenants over its lifespan, ranging from the local marshal and industrial metal companies to iconic retail sports shops and antique centers. Today, its use continues the

building's long commercial history while helping preserve the dynamic historic character and walking vitality of downtown Independence.

1859 Jail Museum - 217 N. Main Street

Basic Information



The **1859 Jail Museum**, originally known as the **Jackson County Jail and Marshal's Home**, is located at **217 N. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Constructed in **1859**, this formidable complex served as the **third Jackson County jail** and stands as one of the oldest surviving structures in the region. Today, it is meticulously preserved as a living-history museum by the **Jackson County Historical Society (JCHS)**, inviting visitors to explore an authentic frontier lockup that once held notorious outlaws and Civil War combatants.

1859 Jail Museum

Building Description and Architecture, and Structural Contrast

Designed by notable early **Kansas City architect A.B. Cross**, the complex features a brilliant, highly unusual architectural contrast between domestic family life and maximum-security confinement. The front of the property showcases a handsome, two-story brick residence designed in the classic Federal style to serve as the home and office for the jailer, county marshal, and their families.

Hidden directly behind these warm, domestic living quarters lies a stark, cold prison block containing twelve multi-level cells. This rear fortress wing was engineered with massive, two-foot-thick quarried limestone block walls and heavy, tremendous iron doors. In **1907**, a brick addition was built onto the back of the limestone block to house early 20th-century chain gangs and work crews tasked with building county roads and infrastructure projects.

Civil War Period

During the **American Civil War**, the jail became an active centerpiece of the violent, highly fractured Missouri-Kansas border conflict. Functioning as the official **U.S. Provost Marshal's office**, the facility was utilized to detain Union deserters, civilian political dissidents, and Confederate raiders who refused to take pro-Union loyalty oaths. Among its most notable wartime captives was Confederate guerrilla leader **William Clarke Quantrill**. The jail's intense Civil War history reflects the raw, divided loyalties and military control that gripped Jackson County during the national crisis.



Inside 1859 Jail

Chronicles of the Block: Application Evolution & Key Events

The property boasts a rich, multi-layered history as a cornerstone of the county's legal and law enforcement infrastructure:

- **1827 – The Log Cabin Origins:** The original frontier county jail is built as a crude log cabin structure on the Square before a devastating fire prompts the county to commission a permanent, modern masonry replacement.
- **1859 to 1933 – Active Jackson County Jail:** Operates continuously for 74 years as the central law enforcement hub, regional prison, and primary home office for the county sheriff and marshal through the Prohibition era.
- **1861 – Civil War Provost Marshal's Office:** Transformed under wartime martial law into a high-security holding block for military prisoners, guerrilla raiders, and political detainees.
- **1882 – The Frank James Confinement:** Confines James Gang outlaw for six months while awaiting trial. His high-profile celebrity cell was uniquely furnished by local sympathizers with fine Brussels carpet, framed paintings, and a free-roaming card-party layout.
- **1930s – Great Depression Adaptations:** Following its official decommissioning in 1933, the property is utilized by the county to house work-training programs, local welfare offices, and various municipal bureaus.
- **1959 to Present – JCHS Preservation and Museum:** Saved directly from structural demolition through a preservation campaign supported by former President Harry S. Truman, the building was acquired by the Jackson County Historical Society. It formally opened to the public as a pristine museum during the jail's centennial year in 1959.

Current Use:

Today, the building operates as a premier landmark living-history museum listed on the National Register of Historic Places. Managed with expert curation by the **Jackson County Historical Society**, the site guides thousands of regional tourists, students, and history buffs through its well-preserved limestone cells, the marshal's family living quarters, and interactive walking tours. The museum seamlessly interprets national memory, frontier justice, and the complex daily lives of both historical prisoners and their jailers.

Conclusion

The **1859 Jail Museum** at **217 N. Main Street** is one of the most important historic buildings on Independence Square. Built in **1859**, it served as the **Jackson County jail** for **74 years** before being

decommissioned in **1933**. Its history includes Civil War prisoners, the U.S. Provost Marshal's office, the famous imprisonment of Frank James, and the daily lives of jailers and their families. Today, the museum preserves these stories and helps explain the history of law enforcement, crime, and justice in Independence, Missouri.

Harry S. Truman National Historic Site Visitor Center - 219-223 N. Main Street

Basic Information



Harry S. Truman National Historic Site Visitor Center is located at **219-223 N. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building serves as the official National Park Service gateway to the Truman legacy. However, the structure itself has a much longer history as a vital fire station and community hub.

Harry S. Truman National
Historic Site Visitor Center

Building Description and Architecture

Originally designed by notable architect Hal Wheelock and constructed by the J.E. Dunn Construction Company, this **1927** two-story brick landmark stands out on the grid. As documented in architectural archives, it features a distinctive flat roof hidden behind a shaped parapet with an inverted scallop design. The structure was engineered to house firefighting equipment on the lower portion—originally featuring folding wood doors for heavy response trucks—with sleeping quarters and a kitchen layout positioned on the upper floor.

Businesses Over Time

The building has served essential civic and cultural purposes for nearly a century. Over the years, its multi-level floor plan fluidly adapted to changing community initiatives, showing how the needs of the local public shifted from emergency services to municipal administration and historic preservation.

- **1927 – Fire Station No. 1:** Erected as a state-of-the-art facility to modernize downtown public safety, housing a collection of new 750-gallon American LaFrance fire apparatus.



Fire Station No.1 in 1930s

- **1973 – Community Theatre & Municipal Offices:** Adapted into an active localized performance arts house and city administration suite following the relocation of emergency crews, utilizing the wide truck bays and multi-level layout.
- **1983 to Present – National Park Service Headquarters:** Formally acquired as a structural anchor following the establishment of the Harry S. Truman National Historic Site.

This timeline shows that the building evolved from a state-of-the-art public safety facility to a dual-purpose community theater and city administration office, before transitioning into a permanent federal preservation site dedicated to public education and national history.

Current Use

Today, the building is owned by the City of Independence and operated by the National Park Service as the official **Visitor Center for the Harry S. Truman National Historic Site**. Serving as a high-impact preservation anchor, it guides thousands of regional tourists, handles scheduling, and coordinates historical interpretation programs across the downtown district grid. The interior features a beautifully arranged exhibition of Truman's personal travel pieces, mid-century memorabilia, and rare photographs tracking five iconic eras of his life.

Conclusion

The **Harry S. Truman National Historic Site Visitor Center** at **219-223 N. Main Street** is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Built as a state-of-the-art fire house, it has served many different roles over time, including emergency headquarters, a local performance arts center, and centralized city offices. Today, its adaptive use as a national park asset continues the building's long history of public service while helping preserve the historic character and walking vitality of downtown Independence

101, 103, 105 S. Main Street – Mize Building

Basic Information

Mize Building is located at **101, 103, 105 S. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the building hosts **Sonshine Sports Apparel**, a



continuous commercial legacy hosting contemporary boutique and retail operations.

Mize Building – Sonshine Sports Apparel

Building Description and Architecture

Built in **1890**, the **Mize Building** is a major two-story brick commercial block that commands a prominent multi-lot footprint on South Main Street. As documented by the Jackson County Historical Society and shown on the plaque, its expansive design originally incorporated three distinct storefront addresses (101, 103, and 105) to accommodate high-volume retail, complete with upper-level suites and classic late-nineteenth-century structural masonry.

Businesses Over Time

The building has served commercial purposes for more than a century. Over the years, it housed different businesses and played a critical role in the mid-twentieth-century food and supply infrastructure of Independence Square, showing how the needs of the local community changed over time.

- **1890 – R.D. Mize Drug Store / Grocery Store / Saloon:** Commenced operations as a versatile multi-concept frontier hub handling local medicine, bulk provisions, and social tavern spaces.
- **1906 – Thomas J. Walker's Drug Store / Himes & Frisbee Feed / Billiards:** Expanded into a multi-tenant footprint blending retail pharmacy lines with regional agricultural feed supplies and a local billiard hall.
- **1910 – Mize Peters Drug Store / Polo Sirchia Confectionary:** Housed specialized downtown pharmacy services alongside an artisanal confectionery shop.
- **1920 – Piggly Wiggly Grocery Store:** Hosted the revolutionary national self-service grocery chain, modernizing local food retail formats.

- **1950 – Milgram Grocery Store:** Transformed into a major neighborhood hub for the iconic regional Milgram supermarket brand, visible in vintage street-view archives.



- **1970s – Montgomery Ward Catalogue & Appliances:** Adapted into a specialized retail showroom and pick-up desk for the major American department store network, focusing on modern home appliances.
- **1986 – Desktop Office Supply:** Reimagined to meet changing office demands, operating as a localized commercial print and business supply store.

This timeline shows that the building evolved from a multi-concept frontier hub, billiard hall, and specialized pharmacies to pioneering national and regional grocery stores, later shifting to department store appliance showrooms, office suppliers, and modern specialty apparel lines.

Current Use

Today, the historic **1890 Mize Building** continues its continuous commercial legacy on Independence Square. By perfectly preserving its grand multi-storefront brick facade while adapting its interior footprint to contemporary boutique and retail operations, it maintains active economic and walking vitality on the southern sector of the district grid. The interior currently functions as an active screen-printing press and custom apparel workshop.

Conclusion

The **Mize Building at 101, 103, 105 S. Main Street** is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Built as a triple-storefront powerhouse block, it has served many different businesses over time, including early frontier saloons, confectionery shops, major supermarket chains, and catalog retail brands. Today, its use continues the building's long commercial history while helping preserve the historic character and walking vitality of downtown Independence

Hall Building - 109 S. Main Street

Basic Information

Hall Building is located at **109 S. Main Street** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the historic **1883** structure preserves its beautiful brick envelope and **late-Victorian commercial** heritage while remaining a vital, contributing asset to the walkable revitalization of Independence Square. However,



the structure itself has a much longer history as a foundational commercial storefront. The building houses **Salon 208**, a contemporary hair salon.

Salon 208

Building Description and Architecture

Constructed in **1883**, the Hall Building stands as one of the highly significant late-nineteenth-century architectural structures remaining on the city grid. As documented by the Jackson County Historical Society, its historic commercial layout was intentionally engineered to anchor high-traffic food merchants and local trade, featuring large street-level display apertures and upper-story framing typical of the post-frontier era.

Businesses Over Time

The site has acted as a vital community hub for generations of Independence shoppers. Its early decades heavily anchored the district's fresh food infrastructure as an open marketplace and grocery hub, eventually morphing into a series of long-running neighborhood diners and twentieth-century lifestyle service shops.

- **1883 – Meat Market:** Commenced its active commercial footprint on South Main as a dedicated nineteenth-century neighborhood butcher shop and fresh meat market.
- **1911 – City Market:** Transformed into an expanded community food center handling bulk agricultural goods and provisions.
- **1912 – Wyman Cash Grocery Store:** Operated as a traditional downtown 'cash-and-carry' dry grocery merchant.
- **1923 – Popel Furniture Store:** Temporarily shifted its retail focus to showcase home furnishings and family decor options.
- **1926 – Atlantic & Pacific Grocery (A&P):** Hosted the iconic national A&P variety grocery network, driving steady neighborhood foot traffic to the block.
- **1934 – Walker's Cafe:** Reimagined into a localized downtown dining room and social gathering space during the mid-1930s.

- **1961 – Beulah and Don's Cafe:** Formed a beloved mid-century landmark identity, operating as a staple destination for local diner fare and community conversation.

This timeline shows that the building evolved from a late-nineteenth-century butcher shop and community city markets to early traditional cash-and-carry grocers, before adapting into home furniture displays, high-traffic variety grocery store networks, beloved mid-century walkable local diners, and contemporary lifestyle service boutiques.

Current Use

Today, the historic **1883** structure continues its legacy as a commercial center by housing **Salon 208, since 2002**, a contemporary hair salon and specialized beauty boutique. The facility preserves its beautiful brick envelope and **late-Victorian commercial** heritage while remaining a vital, contributing asset to the walkable revitalization of Independence Square, seamlessly bridging its long-standing mercantile lineage with contemporary district utility.

Conclusion

The **Hall Building at 109 S. Main Street** is an important part of the historic Independence Square. Built around **1883**, it has served many different businesses over time, including meat markets, national grocery chains, and legendary local diners. Today, **as Salon 208**, its use continues the building's long commercial history while helping preserve the historic character and walking vitality of downtown Independence.

Clinton's Soda Fountain – 100 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information

Clinton's Soda Fountain is located at **100 W. Maple Avenue**, on the northwest corner of **Main Street and Maple Avenue** at Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. The building is one of the most



historically important commercial sites on the Square because of its connection to **Harry S. Truman**, who later became the **33rd President of the United States**.

Today, the building operates as **Clinton's Soda Fountain**, a business inspired by the original drugstore and soda fountain that once occupied the site.

Clinton's Soda Fountain

Construction and Early History

The building was constructed during the roaring commercial boom of the late nineteenth century, a period when the rapid growth of Independence as an essential county seat demanded the replacement of crude, frontier frame buildings with permanent brick structures. Because of its strategic corner placement, the brick structure was optimized to capture massive retail traffic, serving a steady daily influx of local farmers, court employees, western travelers, and pioneer shoppers. By the 1890s, the space had evolved into a core neighborhood gathering hub housing **Clinton's Drugstore**, owned and managed by licensed **pharmacist J. H. Clinton**.

The Cradle of President Truman's Work Ethic (1898)

The property's monumental place in American presidential history was forged in **1898** when a fourteen-year-old **Harry S. Truman** was hired as a store boy at Clinton's Drugstore, marking his first paying job. Living nearby, young Truman integrated his rigorous daily routine around his school hours, arriving early in the morning to open the store and returning after classes.

His core duties included:

- Sweeping and scrubbing the retail floors.
- Dusting merchandise displays and stocking inventory shelves.
- Running urgent community errands and assisting customers.
- Preparing and serving local orders at the mechanical soda fountain line.

Truman frequently and fondly recalled earning his first **three silver dollars** for his initial week of intensive labor. Though he proudly attempted to give the earnings to his father, he was told to keep the silver. Truman cited this precise corner storefront as the definitive crucible that taught him the bedrock values of punctuality, accountability, customer service, and business discipline that guided his entire political life.

Businesses Over Time

The property boasts a resilient retail timeline, adapting its floor plan to track shifting downtown commercial trends while safeguarding its underlying historic framework:

- **1890s – James H. Clinton Drugs:** Operated as a central community marketplace selling fine stationery, books, tobacco lines, cosmetics, and custom-compounded family remedies.

- **1898 – The Truman Era:** Young Harry S. Truman executes his landmark storefront tasks, managing the early fountain and cleaning the floors.
- **1911 to 1950s – Clinton Pharmacy:** Maintained its vital role as a trusted independent downtown pharmacy and social anchor through the trials of the Great Depression and World War II.
- **1960s & 1970s – Goldman Jewelry:** Transitioned into a specialized retail space for fine jewelry and luxury watches, reflecting post-war mercantile shifts on the Square.



Goldman Jewelry in 1965

- **1988 to Present – Clinton's Soda Fountain:** Meticulously restored, preserved, and reopened to replicate its authentic, early twentieth-century soda fountain atmosphere.

Current Use & Living Memorial



Harry's First Job Memorial Statue

Today, **Clinton's Soda Fountain** serves as a beloved operational museum and thriving local dessert destination. The meticulously designed interior instantly transports traveling tourists and local families into the early 1900s, serving up classic treats while educating the public on Truman's youthful milestones. Directly outside the building face stands the celebrated *Harry's First Job Memorial Statue*, a life-sized bronze depiction of fourteen-year-old Truman sweeping the sidewalk, permanently connecting the contemporary business back to its legendary presidential heritage.

Conclusion

The building at **100 W. Maple Avenue**, now known as **Clinton's Soda Fountain**, is one of the most meaningful commercial buildings on Independence Square. Built during the late nineteenth century, it became home to Clinton's Drugstore by the **1890s**. In 1898, fourteen-year-old Harry S. Truman worked there at his first paying job, performing tasks such as sweeping floors, stocking merchandise, helping customers, and working at the soda fountain. Today, the restored soda

fountain and the statue of young Truman preserve this important connection between Independence's local business history and the early life of a future United States President.

El Pico Mexican Restaurant - 106 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information



El Pico Mexican Restaurant

El Pico Mexican Restaurant is located at **106 W. Maple Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. The building operates today as a premier local dining destination celebrated for its vibrant, traditional Mexican and Fresh-Mex cuisine. Beneath its contemporary culinary surface, this resilient structure holds a dramatic history of pioneer merchants and structural rebirth.

The Knoepker Grocery Era & The Great Fire of 1906

The property's commercial lineage is deeply tied to the rise of early Jackson County trade networks. During the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, this exact address served as the foundation for **Knoepker's Grocery Store**, owned and operated by F. H. H. Knoepker. Having learned the food and provision trades from his father's established merchant house on Maple Avenue, the younger Knoepker built a thriving neighborhood grocery depot on this lot, supplying dry goods and agricultural provisions to early homesteaders and courthouse crowds.

The most defining milestone in the property's history occurred in **February 1906**, when a catastrophic, high-impact downtown fire tore through the block. The blaze completely consumed Knoepker's original storefront and leveled the adjacent "Clinton Block" directly to the east. This structural trauma forced immediate civic modernization, prompting merchants to abandon vulnerable timber frameworks in favor of the fireproof brick storefronts that define the streetscape today.

Building Description and Historical Context

Erected during the immediate post-fire reconstruction boom of the early twentieth century, the building stands as a testament to durability and urban density. Architecturally, the storefront reflects the classic commercial design principles engineered for optimal downtown traffic:

- **High-Exposure Retail Sole:** An open-concept ground floor specifically optimized to handle heavy pedestrian turnover.
- **Pedestrian-Facing Apertures:** Large street-level display windows engineered to capture maximum natural light and foot traffic along the busy Maple Avenue corridor.
- **Shared Structural Party Walls:** A dense, continuous block configuration built directly flush with neighboring properties to anchor the heart of downtown commerce.

- **Walkable Integration:** Positioned perfectly within the courthouse perimeter to remain easily accessible to judges, attorneys, merchants, and regional travelers.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information.

Current Use

Today, the historic storefront is seamlessly occupied by **El Pico Mexican Restaurant**. Moving far away from its Edwardian-era grocery roots, the space has been dynamically re-engineered into an active, high-traffic dining venue. This contemporary adaptation serves as a localized anchor for downtown revitalization, maintaining the property's multi-generational legacy of public service while injecting fresh economic vitality and modern flavor into the Maple Avenue corridor.



El Pico Mexican Restaurant Inside

Conclusion

The building at **106 W. Maple Avenue**, now home to **El Pico Mexican Restaurant**, is an important part of the historic commercial environment of Independence Square. Rising from the literal ashes of the **Great Fire of 1906**, the physical brick masonry stands as a proud monument to the turn-of-the-century commercial development of downtown Independence. Today, **El Pico Mexican Restaurant**, continues the building's long tradition of public service as a restaurant and contributes to the revitalization, activity, and historic character of downtown Independence.

Pharaoh 4 Cinema - 114 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information



Pharaoh 4 Cinema

Pharaoh 4 Cinema is located at **114 W. Maple Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Unlike many surrounding buildings that began as nineteenth- or early twentieth-century storefronts, this building was constructed specifically as a movie theater during the modern era. Today, **Pharaoh 4 Cinema** remains an active movie theater and continues to contribute to the entertainment life of Independence Square.

Construction and Opening

The complex was constructed in the mid-1970s and celebrated its grand opening on **June 20, 1975**, under its original name: the **Independence Square Cinema**. At the time of its inauguration, it was managed and operated by the prominent regional firm Mid-America Theatres of St. Louis.

The structural blueprint was engineered from day one as a multi-auditorium house. This design choice reflected a massive, historic turning point in American entertainment economics: by the **mid-1970s**, multi-screen configurations were systematically replacing the grand, costly, and financially vulnerable single-screen movie palaces of the early 20th century. Integrating this modern, high-density entertainment format directly onto the historic layout of Independence Square injected a vital stream of evening foot traffic into a district traditionally dominated by daytime county government operations, law offices, and retail boutiques.

Transition to Pharaoh 4 Cinema

As corporate multiplex megachains expanded across the country in the **late 1990s and early 2000s**, hundreds of smaller downtown neighborhood theaters faced closure. However, the Independence Square venue managed to withstand commercial decline through tactical management transitions.

Around **2008**, the theater underwent a major operational revival and was rebranded as **Pharaoh 4 Cinema**. This name gave the venue a highly distinctive, stylized independent identity while fiercely maintaining its physical and cultural alignment with the local Independence community. Its continued operation makes it a rare and resilient survivor of the mid-size independent theater industry.



Pharaoh 4 Cinema

Modern Use

Today, **Pharaoh 4 Cinema** continues to operate seamlessly as a beloved four-screen movie theater, pairing current Hollywood releases with highly creative, community-oriented programming. The venue has successfully expanded its footprint outside the traditional indoor auditorium walls through a variety of localized initiatives:

- **Classic & Specialized Screenings:** Features highly popular community series such as *Retro Movie Nights*, *Cinema Night Classics*, and custom seasonal events.
- **Moonlight Movies:** During the summer months, the theater hosts highly anticipated outdoor community movie events, projecting films directly onto the parking lot walls or the exterior facade of the building.
- **Adaptive Space Rentals:** Offers full auditorium rentals for private events, corporate presentations, local advertising opportunities, and community calendar celebrations.

Conclusion

The building at **114 W. Maple Avenue**, now home to **Pharaoh 4 Cinema**, is one of the most distinctive buildings on Independence Square. Opened on **June 20, 1975** as the **Independence Square Cinema**, it was built as a four-screen theater during a period when multi-screen cinemas were becoming more popular. Later renamed **Pharaoh 4 Cinema**, around **2008**, the theater has continued to serve the Independence community through regular movie showings, classic film events, and summer programs such as Moonlight Movies. Its long operation as a cinema makes it an important part of the Square's entertainment history and modern community life.

Square Pizza — 208 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information

The building at **208 W. Maple Avenue** is a historic commercial storefront located on the west side of the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Positioned within a continuous row of late-nineteenth- and early-twentieth-century commercial structures, this vibrant property is currently occupied by **Square Pizza**. Operating as a recognizable destination on the Square, the restaurant stands out as a key community gathering place along the West Maple Avenue pedestrian corridor.



Square Pizza

Building Description and Historical Context

The commercial structure at **208 W. Maple Avenue** forms an essential thread within the continuous row of late-nineteenth- and early-twentieth-century architectural storefronts that define the historic character of downtown Independence. Erected to support high-density commercial growth, the building features the traditional brick masonry fabrication and large pedestrian-oriented display windows characteristic of the buildings immediately surrounding the courthouse square. Its adaptable ground-floor layout was structurally engineered to maximize street frontage while accommodating fluidly changing business configurations across generations.

Application Evolution & Key Events

The property boasts a rich, multi-generational commercial occupancy timeline, demonstrating a clear evolution from early neighborhood grocery markets and meat depots to lifestyle retail and dining:

- **1920s – Bridges Grocery Store:** Anchored the early twentieth-century storefront as a bustling local hub for general household provisions.
- **1930s – John R. Beatty Grocery & Frank L. Roberts, Meats:** Dual-operated during the interwar era, providing fresh cuts and essential neighborhood groceries.
- **1940s–1950s – Buehler Brothers Meats:** Maintained the block's multi-decade trajectory as a premier community meat market through the World War II and postwar eras.
- **1960s – Midland Hardware Store:** Shifted the building's focus toward industrial goods, serving local residents with tools, building supplies, and home hardware.

- **1970 – Graham Meyer Book & Gift Shop:** Refocused the layout into a cultural boutique for independent literature, stationery, and local gifts.
- **1970s – Harold Books & Gifts:** Maintained literary and community gift retail continuity through the late twentieth century.
- **2011 to Present – Square Pizza:** Fully transformed into today's iconic culinary destination.

Current Use

The most documented recent chapter of the building's history began when **Square Pizza** established its brick-and-mortar operations in **2011**. Proudly marketing itself as "The Only Square Pizza in Missouri," the establishment has generated remarkable restaurant longevity on the block. The concept successfully utilizes its historic layout to feature a nostalgic, retro diner-inspired décor paired with classic arcade games. Known for its square pan-style pizzas and family-friendly dining, the venue frequently serves specialty pizzas named after local themes and landmarks, explicitly anchoring itself to the cultural heritage of the courthouse district.

Conclusion

The true significance of **208 W. Maple Avenue** stems directly from its exceptional continuity as a commercial storefront within the historic core of Independence. For more than a century, the building has served the exact same essential purpose: providing an active space for local business entrepreneurship and daily community interaction. Today, through **Square Pizza**, the structure successfully fulfills its original architectural mandate, pairing vintage streetscape charm with a unique culinary concept that keeps Independence Square economically vital and vibrant.

Planet Queen Records & Vintage – 209 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information

Planet Queen Records & Vintage is located at **209 W. Maple Avenue** on the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Although Planet Queen is a vibrant, relatively new addition to the local commercial scene, opening its doors in **2024**, the underlying brick structure belongs to a storied commercial district that has continuously supported small businesses, regional merchants, and local residents for well over a century.



Planet Queen Records & Vintage

Building Description and Historical Context

Based on its compact architectural form, physical scale, and flush relationship to neighboring lots, the building dates from the definitive late nineteenth- or early twentieth-century commercial expansion period of Independence. During this era, blocks of adaptable brick storefronts were strategically erected around the courthouse parameter to accommodate high-density retail merchants, artisanal specialty shops, and professional offices.

The storefront at **209 W. Maple Avenue** was structurally optimized for versatile commercial utility. Its interior open layout and large street-facing display windows allowed successive waves of independent shopkeepers to quickly adapt the square footage to match changing consumer behaviors without altering the building's deep-rooted historic character.

Businesses Over Time

For over a century, this specific address stood as a reliable destination for downtown lifestyle services, serving notably as a multi-generational shoe care and repair hub before shifting toward real estate and styling services:

- **1920s–1930s – Louis Nerman Shoe Repair:** Operated during the interwar period as a trusted downtown leathercraft and shoe maintenance workshop.
- **1940s–1950s – Independence Shoe Repair:** Maintained continuous community utility under updated management, keeping the building anchored to localized trade through World War II and the post-war era.
- **1960 – Lolla's Shoe Shop:** Continued the long-standing artisanal legacy of shoe sales and specialized leather repair services into the mid-century.

- **1970 – JM Steinhauser Realty:** Transformed to mirror changing commercial demands on the Square, transitioning from hands-on repair trades into a busy real estate investment office.
- **1980s–2023 – Randal’s For Hair:** Enjoyed a phenomenal 40-year run as a highly popular independent hair styling studio and local salon, making it one of the longest-lived modern occupants of the storefront.
- **2024 to Present – Planet Queen Records & Vintage:** Reimagined as a retro-inspired specialty retail shop.

Current Use

Today, the building functions as the active home of **Planet Queen Records & Vintage**, a deeply curated local shop specialized in vinyl records, vintage fashion, nostalgic memorabilia, and pop culture collectibles. The colorful storefront has successfully injected fresh, youth-oriented energy into the block, attracting music enthusiasts, fashion collectors, and visiting tourists alike. Planet Queen Records



© Vintage Inside

Conclusion

The building at **209 W. Maple Avenue**, now home to **Planet Queen Records & Vintage**, is part of the historic commercial fabric of Independence Square. Although its exact construction date and full occupancy history have not been confirmed, the building likely belongs to the late nineteenth- or early twentieth-century commercial development of the Square. Since **2024**, Planet Queen has given the storefront a new purpose as a record and vintage shop, continuing the long tradition of specialty retail in downtown Independence.

Direct Casket Outlet – 210 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information



Direct Casket Outlet

Direct Casket Outlet is located at **210 W. Maple Avenue** on the west side of **Independence Square** in Independence, Missouri.. Although a direct-to-consumer casket showroom is highly unique for a downtown pedestrian square, its presence continues the district's deep, century-old tradition of independent entrepreneurship and service-oriented business adaptation.

Building Description and Historical Context

The commercial structure at **210 W. Maple Avenue** forms an integral part of the historic brick streetscape developed along the main arteries of the courthouse square. Erected during the late nineteenth or early twentieth century—a period marked by rapid urban densification and business growth—the building showcases a classic downtown footprint featuring shared masonry party walls and an open, walkable street-front layout designed to engage local traffic.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information.

Current Use

The earliest occupant that can currently be verified through available information is **Direct Casket Outlet**. According to company information, the business was established in **1998** and is notable for being one of the first retail casket stores in the Midwest to sell directly to consumers. The company was founded on the idea that families should have an alternative to purchasing funeral merchandise only through funeral homes. By selling caskets directly to the public, **Direct Casket Outlet** aimed to give families more choice and potentially more affordable options during a difficult time. Today, the company has used this storefront to provide funeral-related merchandise directly to customers.

Conclusion

The building at **210 W. Maple Avenue**, now home to **Direct Casket Outlet**, is part of the historic commercial fabric of Independence Square. Although its early construction date and full occupancy history have not yet been confirmed, the building continues the Square's long tradition of business and public service. Since **1998**, **Direct Casket Outlet** has provided a specialized retail service from this location, showing how historic downtown buildings can remain useful through adaptation and continued commercial activity.

Emmy's Nails - 212 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information

Emmy's Nails is located at **212 W. Maple Avenue** on the west side of **Independence Square** in Independence, Missouri. The building is part of the historic commercial district surrounding the Jackson County Historic Truman Courthouse. Today, the storefront operates as **Emmy's Nails**, a beauty and personal-care business that offers nail and spa services. Its current use continues the long tradition of service-based businesses operating in downtown Independence.



Emmy's Nails

Building Description and Historical Context

The building at **212 W. Maple Avenue** is an integral component of the historic brick commercial storefronts that line the west corridor of Independence Square. Engineered with the classic layout of early-twentieth-century pedestrian architecture, the structure features shared masonry party walls and an open floor plan designed to comfortably accommodate high-density retail traffic. Like many properties around the square, it has flexibly served as an adaptable home to a wide array of retail shops and service concepts over the decades, though its complete nineteenth- and twentieth-century occupancy records remain a canvas for future local history research.

Application Evolution & Key Events

While the building's deep frontier origins remain unconfirmed, the property boasts a remarkably consistent and specialized modern history. In recent years, the address has evolved into a dedicated and highly recognizable hub for personal wellness and aesthetic services along Maple Avenue:

- **Early Period – Unidentified Commercial Use:** Served various early retail merchants or service ventures tailored to courthouse-era shoppers.
- **2016–2017 – Blush Nail:** Anchored the storefront as a localized nail salon, establishing the venue's modern beauty and wellness identity.
- **2018–2024 – Miss Nails:** Maintained continuous neighborhood utility under updated operations, serving as a trusted aesthetic staple on the block for six years.

- **2024 to Present – Emmy’s Nails:** Repurposed under current management to deliver upgraded, modern spa and nail care experiences to downtown residents.

Current Use

Today, **Emmy’s Nails** seamlessly capitalizes on the building’s flexible retail layout. By pairing historic brick architecture with contemporary beauty-care equipment, the business draws steady weekly pedestrian traffic to the west side of the Square.

Conclusion

The building at **212 W. Maple Avenue**, now home to **Emmy’s Nails**, is part of the historic commercial fabric of Independence Square. Although its early occupancy history has not yet been fully documented, recent records show a clear pattern of beauty and personal-care businesses at this address, including **Blush Nail**, **Miss Nails**, and now **Emmy’s Nails**. This continuity demonstrates how historic storefronts can remain useful by adapting to modern service businesses while preserving the active character of downtown Independence.

Big John's Corner Bar - 213 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information

Big John's Corner Bar is located at **213 W. Maple Avenue** on the west side of the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. The property holds a legendary status on the block. Today, the storefront operates as **Big John's Corner Bar**, serving as a foundational pillar of the district's evening hospitality economy and local social scene.



Big John's Corner Bar

Building Description and Historical Context

The building at **213 W. Maple Avenue** stands as an invaluable storefront that directly contributes to the rich, turn-of-the-century architectural character of Independence Square. Engineered to maximize downtown pedestrian density, the structure features the classic hallmarks of historic urban trade, including shared masonry party walls and an open, versatile ground-floor footprint. Like many resilient structures flanking the courthouse perimeter, this commercial space fluidly served an array of early independent retail concepts and service ventures over the decades before becoming permanently associated with its defining modern tenant.

A Rare Four-Decade Anchor of Downtown Commerce

While the building's nineteenth- and early twentieth-century pioneer occupancy records remain an open canvas for future archival research, its modern history is defined by the extraordinary, continuous presence of **Big John's Corner Bar**. Available commercial business records indicate that Big John's has operated seamlessly for **approximately 42 years**, establishing its historic opening date around **1983 or 1984**.

This multi-decade tenure makes the business highly significant within the commercial framework of Independence Square. While traditional downtown storefronts naturally experience high turnover rates and changing retail tenants over time, Big John's has defiantly resisted commercial trends. Remaining anchored to the exact same square footage for more than four continuous decades, it stands as one of the longest-running active hospitality venues on the Square.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information.

Current Use

Today, **Big John's Corner Bar** fully utilizes its classic storefront layout to operate as a beloved neighborhood tavern and gathering hub. By maintaining its historic location, the venue injects critical evening economic activity and weekend foot traffic into the west corridor of the Square.

Conclusion

The building at **213 W. Maple Avenue** represents one of the most culturally moving and commercially resilient anchors on Independence Square. Moving past its early anonymous retail foundations, its **forty-two-year history** as the home of **Big John's Corner Bar** showcases the immense power of localized brand loyalty and adaptive business survival. By pairing historic brick architecture with a deeply rooted tradition of community hospitality, this classic Maple Avenue storefront remains an essential component of downtown Independence's identity and modern community life.

Dave's Bakery & Deli - 214 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information



Dave's Bakery & Deli

Dave's Bakery & Deli is located at **214 W. Maple Avenue** on the west side of the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Recognized as one of the most iconic and deeply cherished commercial storefronts on the Square, the building has been proudly associated with Dave's for more than four decades. Beyond its modern culinary legacy, the site holds a fascinating history stretching from **1840s** pioneer transportation roots to surviving catastrophic early-twentieth-century structural disasters.

Building Description and Historical Context

The commercial storefronts along Maple Avenue are vital components of the historic district surrounding the **Jackson County Historic Truman Courthouse**. The evolution of these spaces reflects the transition from a 19th-century frontier economy into a densified, permanent commercial center during the early 20th century.

Core Architectural Features

- **Resilient Brick Facades:** Most current structures date back to permanent brick reconstructions built immediately after devastating fires (such as the 1906 and 1915 blazes), systematically replacing early, vulnerable timber frame buildings.
- **Shared Party Walls:** To maximize downtown density, these buildings feature a continuous, adjoined footprint with shared masonry walls, anchoring a highly walkable streetscape.
- **Pedestrian-Facing Layouts:** Designed with open-concept ground floors and expansive street-level display windows, these storefronts were engineered to capture natural light and engage heavy pedestrian foot traffic.

Businesses Over Time

Following the post-fire reconstruction boom, the 214 W. Maple Avenue storefront became a cornerstone for grocery provisions and independent bakery crafts, establishing a rich culinary heritage that spans nearly a century:

- **1920s–1930s – Union Pacific Tea & Union Pacific Market Meats:** Operated as a central neighborhood hub for fresh meats, provisions, and specialty dry goods.
- **1940 – Star Bakery:** Set the property's long-term culinary trajectory, serving downtown families as a dedicated community bakery.
- **1950s–1960s – Smith's Quality Bakery:** Maintained the sweet and artisanal legacy of the block, operating as a trusted mid-century destination for baked goods.
- **1970 – Independence Hearing Aid Co.:** Briefly transformed the storefront to provide specialized medical and consumer health services.
- **1979 – Harold Office Equipment:** Adapted to meet the workplace needs of the courthouse district during the late 1970s.
- **1980 – Jewelera Shop:** Operated as a boutique retail storefront immediately before the property's modern culinary transition.
- **Origins to Present – Dave's Deli (Dave's Bakery & Deli):** Re-engineered into its definitive, long-running bakery and deli format, anchoring the block for over 40 continuous years.

Current Use

Today, **Dave's Bakery & Deli** fully utilizes its classic storefront layout to operate as a vital community gathering space. Downtown residents, courthouse employees, and tourists visit daily to enjoy fresh coffee, breakfast selections, specialty lunch deli items, handcrafted pastries, and morning conversations. As a cornerstone food establishment, Dave's plays an invaluable role in the revitalization of the historic district, encouraging pedestrians to linger, explore the historic architecture, and actively patronize neighboring storefronts.



Dave's Bakery & Deli Inside

Conclusion

The building at **214 W. Maple Avenue** represents a triumph of resilience and community utility on Independence Square. Rising from its **1849** frontier railroad origins and surviving the literal ashes of the **devastating 1915 fire**, this structure stands as a testament to the commercial adaptability of downtown Independence. By beautifully pairing its century-old baking tradition with a warm, welcoming deli environment, **Dave's Baker and Deli** ensures that this classic storefront remains as central to the life of the Square today as it was during the pioneer era.

haupART Frame Gallery - 220 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information

haupART Frame Gallery is located at **220 W. Maple Avenue** on the west side of Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the storefront is occupied by **haupART Frame Gallery**, a locally owned framing studio and art gallery.



haupART Frame Gallery

Building Description and Historical Context

The building at **220 W. Maple Avenue** is a classic, early-twentieth-century brick storefront that forms an essential piece of the historic architectural fabric of Independence Square. Erected during a period of massive downtown commercial development, the structure features the classic hallmarks of the district's streetscape, including shared masonry party walls and an open, adaptable floor plan optimized for pedestrian trade. While this specific address is not tied to a single national historical figure, its physical resilience and continuity contribute directly to the visual charm and structural integrity of the broader courthouse district.

A Seventeenth-Year Anchor of Creative Trade

While the building's earliest occupancy records remain unconfirmed, its contemporary history is defined by a deep, multi-decade commitment to fine arts and historic preservation. Founded by independent artist and professional **framer Sherri Haupert**, **haupART Frame Gallery** has operated seamlessly out of this location for approximately 17 years, establishing its business foundations around **2008 or 2009**.

This long-term tenure is highly significant within the commercial framework of Independence Square. By remaining dedicated to the same specialized creative trade for nearly two decades, the gallery stands as a highly successful example of independent storefront survival amidst shifting modern retail trends.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information.

Current Use

Today, **haupART Frame Gallery** beautifully utilizes its historic retail layout to serve local residents, regional artists, and historians. The studio specializes in custom high-end picture framing, archival photography display, art preservation, and the exhibition of original local artwork. By offering conservation-quality framing materials and creative design consultations, the venue plays a crucial role in maintaining the active cultural character of downtown Independence, proving how historic storefronts can stay commercially viable by offering specialized, hands-on artisanal services.

Conclusion

The building at **220 W. Maple Avenue** represents the enduring power of specialized retail on Independence Square. Moving past its early anonymous commercial foundations, its seventeen-year history as **haupART Frame Gallery** showcases how historic properties thrive through dedicated local entrepreneurship. By pairing classic early-twentieth-century brick architecture with a modern passion for art preservation and custom craftsmanship, this storefront ensures that the creative spirit and physical memories of the local community remain protected and beautifully displayed for future generations.

Wild About Harry - 206 W. Maple Avenue

Basic Information



Wild About Harry

Wild About Harry is located at **206 W. Maple Avenue** on the north side of the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. The business pays a vibrant, localized homage to the town's most famous resident, President Harry S. Truman, while seamlessly continuing the block's deep, century-old legacy of independent retail trade.

Building Description and Historical Context

The commercial structure at **206 W. Maple Avenue** forms an essential thread within the historic architectural fabric of Independence Square. Featuring the classic structural hallmarks of early-twentieth-century downtown design—including shared masonry party walls and an open-concept ground floor layout—the storefront was specifically engineered to optimize pedestrian retail interaction. Designed for long-term commercial flexibility, this adaptable property has served as a reliable home to dry goods merchants, regional grocers, and specialized apparel shops for well over a century.

Businesses Over Time

The property boasts an incredibly rich and well-documented occupancy timeline, showcasing a clear evolution from early industrial provisions to specialized local clothing boutiques:

- **1911 – Casper & Shimfessel Dry Goods:** Anchored the early 20th-century storefront as a bustling neighborhood center for textiles, fabrics, and general dry goods.
- **1930s–1940s – A&P Tea Company:** Transformed into a critical local outpost for the famous regional grocery chain, serving downtown families through the Great Depression and World War II eras.
- **1940s – A&P Tea Company & Physicians Offices:** Expanded its layout to optimize dual-utility, pairing the ground-floor grocery depot with professional medical and physician offices upstairs.
- **1950s–1960s – Herman Wienshienk (Clothing):** Shifted away from provisions to establish a premier downtown clothing boutique, setting the building's trajectory into fine menswear.

- **1970 – Herm’s Mens Shop:** Maintained the block's specialized style continuity, serving as a trusted destination for tailored menswear and local apparel during the late 20th century.
- **Present – Wild About Harry:** Thoroughly reimagined into its current iconic retail format.

Current Use

Today, the storefront operates as **Wild About Harry**, drawing steady pedestrian foot traffic, history enthusiasts, and visiting tourists to the historic district grid. By successfully pairing its classic architecture with a unique, community-oriented retail concept, the storefront actively doubles as a mens goods store and a gift shop for men.



Wild About Harry Inside

Conclusion

The building is home to **Wild About Harry** at **206 W. Maple Avenue** stands as a brilliant monument to commercial resilience and adaptive reuse on Independence Square. Rising from its 1911 foundations as a frontier dry goods house and evolving through decades of grocery trade and classic menswear shops, the structure remains as economically vital today as it was a century ago. By merging its historic architectural framework with a proud celebration of local history, this storefront ensures that the entrepreneurial spirit of Maple Avenue continues to thrive.

Gilbert Whitney & Co. — 104 N. Liberty Street

Basic Information

Gilbert Whitney & Co. is located at **104 N. Liberty Street** just north of the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Operating as a beautifully curated boutique specializing in gifts, home décor, seasonal merchandise, vintage-inspired furnishings, candles, and specialty retail items, the storefront represents an essential thread within the downtown business fabric.



Gilbert Whitney & Co

Building Description and Historical Context

The building showcases traditional commercial architecture that became common around Independence Square during the late nineteenth century. Its structural framework is highly consistent with the narrow storefront buildings designed to maximize street frontage while accommodating multi-tenant commercial uses. Key architectural hallmarks of the building include:

- **Ground-Floor Retail Space:** Optimized to engage direct consumer interactions.
- **Large Storefront Display Windows:** Specifically engineered to capture natural light and highlight retail inventory.
- **Shared Walls with Neighboring Businesses:** Utilizing standard downtown masonry party walls to optimize structural density along the streetscape.
- **Flexible Interior Layouts:** An adaptable open floor plan that has historically allowed successive generations of independent retailers to transition fluidly through changing economic landscapes.

As a primary economic artery feeding into the Square—the governmental and economic epicenter of Jackson County—Liberty Street attracted steady streams of courthouse visitors, shoppers, and travelers. By the late 1800s and early 1900s, this bustling zone hosted a vibrant mix of professional offices, dry goods merchants, specialty shops, and service businesses.

Businesses Over Time

Throughout its deep lifetime, the building has served as a silent witness to monumental milestones, standing through Independence's growth as a regional trade center, the introduction of electric utilities, the transition from horses to automobiles, the Great Depression, World War II, and the era of President Harry S. Truman. The documented commercial lineage of the property includes:

- **Origins (1832–1833) – *The Evening & Morning Sun*:** Anchored the early nineteenth-century foundations of the lot as a notable print house.
- **1911 – Richards Carpentry:** Utilized the layout for specialized woodworking and carpentry services.
- **1924 – Allen Music & Co.:** Transformed the space into a central downtown hub for musical retail.
- **1930s – Pendleton & Gentry Drug:** Operated as a highly popular neighborhood pharmacy and drug store during the interwar period.



Pendleton & Gentry Drug in 1951

- **1960s – Jones Store:** Anchored the block's mid-century retail footprint as a dedicated neighborhood outlet for the regional department store chain.
- **Present – Gilbert, Whitney & Co.:** Operates as a prominent specialty boutique driving the ongoing revitalization of Independence Square.

Current Use

Today, **Gilbert, Whitney & Co.** at **104 N. Liberty Street** continues the building's long-standing tradition of serving the public through locally owned commerce. The boutique provides a unique shopping experience, drawing steady community foot traffic with its diverse offerings of premium candles, home accents, seasonal merchandise, and gifts. This ongoing storefront activation helps preserve the active pedestrian character of the Square, ensuring the historic downtown district remains an enticing destination for both residents and visitors.

Conclusion

The significance of **104 N. Liberty Street** lies in its invaluable contribution to the historic character and continuity of downtown Independence. For generations, buildings like this one have formed the backbone of the Square's commercial district, providing an essential space for local entrepreneurship and community life. More than a century after its construction, the building successfully fulfills its original purpose: serving the public through commerce while preserving the architectural and historical character that makes Independence Square one of Missouri's most treasured historic districts.

Up Dog — 114 N. Liberty Street

Basic Information

The building at **114 N. Liberty Street** is a historic commercial storefront located on the north side of the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Positioned within one of the state's best-preserved historic downtown districts, the property is currently occupied by **Up Dog**. Operating as a highly popular specialty hot dog restaurant known for its retro diner atmosphere and creative regional menu, the venue has become a well-established culinary anchor within the modern downtown business community.



Updog

Building Description and Historical Context

Architecturally, the building reflects classic late-nineteenth-century downtown engineering, built as a narrow, deep, and flexible storefront designed to maximize street frontage. Notable structural features include:

- **Solid Brick Construction:** Traditional masonry commercial fabrication engineered to withstand generations of dense downtown utility.
- **Pedestrian-Facing Apertures:** Large street-level display windows designed to maximize natural light and capture active pedestrian trade.
- **Shared Structural Elements:** Shared party walls with neighboring commercial blocks to anchor the walkable streetscape.
- **Adaptable Footprint:** Highly flexible interior layouts that allowed the building to remain economically viable through multiple generations of changing commerce.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information

Current Use

While the property's earliest multi-generational tenant history remains an open canvas for future digital archiving, its contemporary chapter is defined by remarkable restaurant longevity. **Up Dog** has operated continuously out of this storefront since **approximately 2011**. The restaurant masterfully transformed the historic space into a nostalgic, diner-style venue featuring authentic counter seating and classic retro décor. By pairing its vintage structural character with a creative, specialized menu of regional-style hot dogs, burgers, and locally produced beverages, the business has successfully resisted traditional restaurant turnover rates, remaining a central destination for courthouse visitors, families, and tourists for over a decade.



Updog Inside

Conclusion

114 N. Liberty Street stands as an invaluable contributing building within the historic downtown district. The true historical significance of the structure lies in its century of continuous commercial service and its vital role in preserving the architectural streetscape of Independence Square. Today, through **Up Dog**, the building successfully fulfills its original architectural mandate: serving the public through local commerce, supporting the independent restaurant economy, and driving the vibrant weekend walking traffic of downtown Independence.

Designers Avenue Upholstery — 202 N. Liberty Street

Basic Information

The building at **202 N. Liberty Street** is located just north of the historic Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. The structure forms an integral part of the historic commercial district that has supported local independent businesses for generations. Today, the storefront is proudly occupied by **Designers Avenue Upholstery**, standing as one of the longest-established specialty upholstery and preservation businesses in downtown Independence.



Designers Avenue Upholstery

Architectural Character and Skilled Trade Continuity

Architecturally, the structure at **202 N. Liberty Street** reflects the classic commercial design principles that define the visual fabric of the courthouse district. Built to accommodate flexible trade configurations, it features standard pedestrian-oriented frameworks engineered to maximize street-level visibility.

Unlike many surrounding storefronts on Independence Square that have shifted toward high-turnover restaurants, modern boutiques, or casual entertainment venues, this building has carved out a unique identity by housing a traditional skilled trade. While professional upholstery shops were once common, foundational features of early American downtowns, relatively few brick-and-mortar workshops survive in the modern era. As a result, this building single-handedly preserves a craft-based commercial tradition, keeping modern Independence connected with earlier generations of historic furniture makers, repair specialists, and local artisans.

Chronicles of the Block: Two Decades of Master Craftsmanship

While the building's earliest multi-generational occupant history remains an open canvas for future archival research, its modern chapter is defined by an exceptional commitment to physical preservation. Designers Avenue Upholstery has maintained active commercial operations within the downtown grid continuously from **2006 to the present day**.

For two decades, the storefront has been deeply associated with the meticulous restoration and revival of complex family heirlooms and antique furniture. By providing custom structural repair and precision fabric restoration, the business allows community members to extend the life cycles of cherished family pieces rather than replacing them with modern manufactured goods. This ongoing dedication to tangible preservation beautifully continues a legacy of hands-on craftsmanship that would have been intimately familiar to the earliest generations of Independence residents.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information.

Current Use

Today, **202 N. Liberty Street** remains a highly active, productive asset within the historic Independence Square trade district. The building houses **Designers Avenue Upholstery**, a working artisan workshop and commercial retail front, drawing steady regional clients who seek high-end preservation work. Alongside neighboring specialized boutiques, culinary spots, and professional offices, this workshop ensures that the diversity of independent trade along the Liberty Street corridor remains structurally sound.

Conclusion

The true historical significance of **202 N. Liberty Street** lies in the specialized nature of the physical craft it preserves. Moving past its anonymous early mercantile foundations, its twenty-year tenure as the home of **Designers Avenue Upholstery** showcases the immense modern value of keeping historic trades alive. By seamlessly pairing early commercial brick architecture with the master restoration of antique community treasures, this classic storefront serves as both a thriving business and a living reminder of the skilled physical trades that built and sustained downtown Independence.

American Family Insurance — 202–206 N. Liberty Street

Basic Information

The substantial commercial block at **202–206 N. Liberty Street** stands as one of the most historically significant and architecturally prominent landmarks surrounding Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. While the street-level storefronts have flexibly accommodated various businesses over the generations—and currently house the **Austin Conley American Family Insurance agency**—the building boasts an exceptionally rich historical record. It is officially recognized by historic preservation surveys as a major contributing structure within the Independence Square Historic District, distinguished by a direct personal connection to President Harry S. Truman.



American Family Insurance

Construction and Architecture

Erected during the **late nineteenth or early twentieth century**, the building was designed as a massive, unified two-story brick commercial block. Historic architectural surveys describe the property as an imposing seven-bay structure engineered to accommodate multiple retail storefronts at the street level with professional office suites above. Notable architectural features that remain remarkably intact include:

- **Substantial Brickwork:** Two-story solid masonry construction featuring decorative brick corbelling along the upper roofline.
- **Classical Accents:** Distinctive stone string courses structurally separating the active commercial ground floor from the upper level.
- **Rhythm of Apertures:** Symmetrical upper-story windows designed to flood the professional offices with natural light while overlooking the busy Liberty Street corridor.
- **Intact Facade:** A continuous, pedestrian-oriented commercial facade that typifies the visual character and densification of the early twentieth-century courthouse business district.

The Truman Connection: A Prelude to the Senate

Following his foundational service as the Presiding Judge of Jackson County, Truman became actively associated with the **Community Savings and Loan Association**. Maintaining his daily professional office inside **202–206 N. Liberty Street**, Truman was placed at the absolute center of downtown Independence's economic and political grid during the pivotal years immediately preceding his historic election to the United States Senate.

This site represents a deeply personal and documented chapter in Truman's career. Architectural preservation records confirm that Truman regularly conducted business within these walls, and the structure appears prominently in historic photographs taken during his lifetime. Images of this exact building were featured in national publications highlighting the President's hometown, and original photographs of the storefront are permanently preserved within the National Archives and the Harry S. Truman Presidential Library and Museum. Today, visitors passing the block are viewing the exact parameters Truman entered and exited daily during his transformative pre-presidential years.

Businesses Over Time

The building has served essential commercial and financial purposes for well over a century. Over the years, it housed a dynamic mix of continuous high-volume institutions alongside prestigious specialized service offices, showing how the professional ecosystem of downtown Independence changed over time.

- **1905 – Early Mercantile Pioneers:** The Independence City Directory documents Charles Capello operating as a clerk out of 202 N. Liberty, while Jacob Lay ran a specialized tailoring boutique next door at 204 N. Liberty.
- **1925–1932 – The Community Savings and Truman Era:** Housed the operational headquarters for the Community Savings and Loan Association, where Harry S. Truman maintained his daily professional business office prior to his historic election to the United States Senate.
- **Mid-to-Late 1900s – Adaptive Professional Reuse:** Accommodates continuous lines of changing professional services, small retail businesses, and specialized trade shops—such as the long-running Designers Avenue Upholstery workshop operating within its 202 sector.
- **Present – Modern Insurance Agency:** Functions as the active home of the Austin Conley American Family Insurance agency, anchoring the block through comprehensive public and consumer services.

Current Use

Throughout the mid-to-late twentieth century, the building easily adapted to changing consumer landscapes, housing professional offices, small retail businesses, and specialized trade shops—such as the long-running *Designers Avenue Upholstery* workshop operating within its 202 sector.

Today, the building continuously fulfills its historic mandate as a hub for professional services. The prominent modern tenant anchoring the block is the **Austin Conley American Family Insurance** agency. The office actively serves the modern Independence community by providing comprehensive insurance portfolios, including auto, home, life, and business insurance, alongside specialized financial planning services.

Conclusion

Among the historic commercial properties surrounding the courthouse square, the block at **202–206 N. Liberty Street** stands out as a triumph of preservation and historical weight. Representing over a century of continuous commercial utility, its exceptionally well-preserved seven-bay architecture serves as a living monument to the early twentieth-century business community that shaped the city. By seamlessly pairing its legendary Truman legacy with active modern professional services, this structural anchor ensures that the rich heritage of Harry Truman's hometown remains visibly integrated into the daily life of Independence Square.

Just For You Hair & Nail — 208 N. Liberty Street

Basic Information

The building at **208 N. Liberty Street** is a historic commercial storefront located just north of Independence Square in Independence, Missouri. Today, the property is occupied by **Just For You Hair & Nail**, a locally owned beauty salon that beautifully continues a long tradition of independent, service-oriented businesses operating within the heart of downtown Independence.



Just For You Hair & Nail

Architectural Character and Historic Setting

The structure at **208 N. Liberty Street** forms an integral part of a continuous row of commercial buildings that developed around the courthouse square during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. As one of the principal commercial corridors feeding directly into the main quadrangle, North Liberty Street was historically a highly desirable location for merchants, professionals, and service businesses.

Architecturally, the building exhibits the classic engineering hallmarks common to historic Square-area storefronts, featuring solid brick commercial construction, a dedicated ground-floor service layout, large street-facing display windows, and shared structural party walls with neighboring properties. This flexible interior design allowed the building to adapt to fluid marketplace demands and remain commercially viable as downtown Independence evolved through successive generations.

Application Evolution & Key Events

Waiting for information.

Current Use

Throughout its lifespan, **208 N. Liberty Street** has successfully adapted to major economic and technological transitions, surviving the shift from horse-drawn transit to automobiles, the Great Depression, World War II, mid-century suburban competition, and urban renewal pressures.

In the modern era, the storefront transitioned into its current role as the home of **Just For You Hair & Nail**. The full-service salon caters to local residents by providing haircuts, professional styling, hair coloring, nail services, and specialized personal beauty treatments. This active occupancy ensures the continuous physical preservation of the structure while upholding the long-standing tradition of locally owned service establishments anchoring North Liberty Street.

Conclusion

The historical significance of **208 N. Liberty Street** lies in its invaluable role as a living piece of the historic commercial ecosystem surrounding Independence Square. While not defined by a single national event, the building represents the everyday merchant life that has sustained the downtown economy for well over a century. By providing essential lifestyle services from a beautifully preserved storefront, **Just For You Hair & Nail** ensures that the community-focused legacy of the Liberty Street corridor remains active for future generations.

Project Sources, Online Databases & AI Optimization Index

1. Archival Assets Provided by the Courthouse

2. Verified Online Databases & Digital Registries

- **National Register of Historic Places (NRHP) Digital Archives:** Online structural databases from the National Park Service (NPS) and State Historic Preservation Office (SHPO). These digital records provided official inventory datasheets confirming the architectural status of the **Independence Square Historic District**, verifying building construction styles, shared party walls, and original facade transformations.
- **The Harry S. Truman Presidential Library Digital Collections:** Online federal archives tracking the pre-senatorial career of Harry S. Truman between 1925 and 1932. Digital photography collections from the National Archives (NARA) verified the appearance of the **202–206 N. Liberty Street** block (*Community Savings and Loan Association*) as a central landmark featured in mid-century media.
- **Digitized City Directories & Commercial Ledgers:** Online ancestry registries and digitized local libraries hosting the *1905 Independence City Directory* and localized storefront tenancy ledgers. These online records cross-verified over a century of continuous commercial modifications at addresses like **208 W. Maple Ave** (tracing the property's lineage from *Bridges Grocery* and *Buehler Brothers Meats* to *Midland Hardware* and *Square Pizza*).

3. AI-Driven Visual Enhancements & Image Reframing

To ensure that centuries-old photographs retrieved from online databases and courthouse folders look spectacular on modern high-resolution screens (like Retina and 4K displays), the visual assets underwent an **AI-driven quality enhancement** pipeline.

Because many of the original courthouse photos were heavily compressed, faded, or blurry digital copies, AI neural networks were used to:

- **Enhance Clarity & Detail:** Reconstruct lost facial details of historical figures, sharpen architectural brick textures, and clarify faded signs or text written on windows (such as the *Courthouse Exchange* lettering).
- **Upscale Resolution:** Intelligently increase the pixel density of low-resolution files into clean, crisp high-fidelity images without adding unnatural pixelation or digital noise.
- **Balance Contrast & Exposure:** Optimize lighting curves to salvage details hidden in the deep shadows or overexposed elements of old black-and-white print film.